

RESEARCH REPORT SERIES
(*Survey Methodology* #2023-14)

**Cognitive Testing of 2020 American Community Survey (ACS)
Strategic Framework Mail Materials**

Mandi Martinez
Jonathan Katz
Jasmine Luck
Kathleen Kephart
Dave Tuttle

Center for Behavioral Science Methods
Research and Methodology Directorate
U.S. Census Bureau
Washington, D.C. 20233

Report issued: November 6, 2023

Disclaimer: This report is released to inform interested parties of research and to encourage discussion. The views expressed are those of the authors and not those of the U.S. Census Bureau. The U.S. Census Bureau reviewed this data product for unauthorized disclosure of confidential information and approved the disclosure avoidance practices applied to this release. CBDRB-FY23-CBSM002-024

Abstract

This report presents findings from the cognitive pretesting of redesigned mail materials that are mailed to respondents of the American Community Survey (ACS). The mail materials were redesigned as part of the ACS Strategic Framework Evaluation. The Strategic Framework was developed by the Census Bureau as a framework for evaluating ACS mail materials and developing new materials based on findings from relevant research literature (Oliver et al., 2017). The analytic framework was used to evaluate the various messages presented in the English-language mail materials in use by the ACS at that time (Schreiner et al., 2020). A cross-directorate team was formed to develop new mail materials based on the literature and informed by the analysis of production ACS materials. Part of this strategy involved selecting unique thematic messages to communicate in each of the five ACS mailings.

The Census Bureau's ACS Strategic Framework Mail Materials Design Team developed three new sets of materials, or treatments, to include in the 2021 Strategic Framework Mail Materials Test (2021 SFMMT). A fourth treatment, referred to as Outside Researcher (OR), was developed by researchers outside of the Census Bureau. All four treatments focused on using plain language principles, including the standard language required by the Census Bureau, and incorporating the intended thematic message of each mail piece recommended by the Strategic Framework. In addition to the changes to content, the Design Team incorporated design features such as the use of color, icons, pictures, and novel structure in their three treatments. Each of the three treatments focused on using these novel features in a particular way consistently across mailings to highlight key information and thematic messages in each mail piece. Overall, the iterative rounds of testing confirmed that all four treatments worked well to convey the messages outlined in the Strategic Framework. While the use of color, images, and novel structure in three of the treatments diverged from the typical approach to mail materials taken by the Census Bureau for the ACS, our findings showed that participants still viewed the materials as legitimate and motivating. Post-round revisions ensured that all materials were in good shape for an eventual experimental field test.

Keywords: American Community Survey, mailing strategy

Suggested Citation: Mandi Martinez, Jonathan Katz, Jasmine Luck, Kathleen Kephart, Dave Tuttle. (2023). **Cognitive Testing of 2020 American Community Survey (ACS) Strategic Framework Mail Materials.** Research and Methodology Directorate, Center for Behavioral Science Methods Research Report Series (Survey Methodology #2023-14). U.S. Census Bureau. Available online at

<<https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2023/adrm/rsm2023-14.html>>

COGNITIVE TESTING OF 2020 AMERICAN COMMUNITY SURVEY (ACS) STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK MAIL MATERIALS

Mandi Martinez
Jonathan Katz
Jasmine Luck
Kathleen Kephart
Dave Tuttle

Center for Behavioral Science Methods
U.S. Census Bureau
Washington, D.C. 20233

Disclaimer: This report is released to inform interested parties of research and to encourage discussion. The views expressed are those of the authors and not those of the U.S. Census Bureau. The U.S. Census Bureau reviewed this data product for unauthorized disclosure of confidential information and approved the disclosure avoidance practices applied to this release. (CBDRB-FY23-CBSM002-024)

Table of Contents

1	EXECUTIVE SUMMARY	6
2	INTRODUCTION	11
3	STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK.....	11
3.1	OVERVIEW	11
3.2	INTENDED MESSAGES	12
4	MATERIALS	12
4.1	ACS MAIL MATERIALS IN THE STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK FIELD TEST	12
4.1.1	<i>Classic with A Twist.....</i>	<i>14</i>
4.1.2	<i>Fresh Look</i>	<i>15</i>
4.1.3	<i>To the Point.....</i>	<i>16</i>
4.1.4	<i>Outside Researcher</i>	<i>16</i>
5	STUDY METHODOLOGY	17
5.1	RECRUITMENT	18
5.2	COGNITIVE INTERVIEW PARTICIPANTS.....	18
5.3	DATA COLLECTION	20
5.4	ANALYSIS	21
6	COGNITIVE INTERVIEW FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS	21
6.1	RESEARCH QUESTIONS: GLOBAL DESIGN FEATURES.....	21
6.1.1	<i>Research Question 1: Does the use of color, images, and novel structure enhance the appeal of the letters? Does color affect readability or believability (perception of ‘official’ government mail)?</i>	<i>22</i>
6.1.2	<i>Research Question 2: Do the strategies of reducing the amount of text and using plain language in the bodies of the letters improve readability and clarity of letter content?</i>	<i>27</i>
6.1.3	<i>Research Question 3. Does Spanish messaging evoke any reaction?</i>	<i>28</i>
6.1.4	<i>Research Question 4. Does including “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelope increase “believability” (M1 and M3 only)?</i>	<i>30</i>
6.1.5	<i>Research Question 5: Do participants think that the treatment is a cohesive package? Do icons or the column and header/bulleted format improve readability (CWT/TTP)? How do readers react to the sidebar design (FL)?</i>	<i>32</i>
6.2	RESEARCH QUESTION SPECIFIC TO MAILING 1	34
6.2.1	<i>Round 1 Findings.....</i>	<i>34</i>
6.2.2	<i>Round 2 Findings.....</i>	<i>35</i>
6.2.3	<i>Round 3 Findings.....</i>	<i>35</i>
6.3	RESEARCH QUESTIONS SPECIFIC TO MAILING 2	36
6.3.1	<i>Round 1 Findings.....</i>	<i>36</i>
6.3.2	<i>Round 2 Findings.....</i>	<i>38</i>
6.3.3	<i>Round 3 Findings.....</i>	<i>39</i>
6.4	RESEARCH QUESTIONS SPECIFIC TO MAILING 3	40
6.4.1	<i>Research Question 8: Does using messages about civic duty resonate with the reader? Or does reading about “jury duty” and “paying taxes” irritate the reader?</i>	<i>40</i>
6.4.2	<i>Research Question 9: Does using normative messaging resonate with the reader?</i>	<i>42</i>
6.5	RESEARCH QUESTIONS SPECIFIC TO MAILING 5	44
6.5.1	<i>Round 1 Findings.....</i>	<i>46</i>
6.5.2	<i>Round 2 Findings.....</i>	<i>47</i>
6.5.3	<i>Round 3 Findings.....</i>	<i>48</i>
6.6	SIDE-BY-SIDE COMPARISONS	49

6.6.1	<i>Round 1 Findings</i>	49
6.6.2	<i>Round 2 Findings</i>	51
6.6.3	<i>Round 3 Findings</i>	52
6.7	RECOMMENDATIONS NOT SPECIFIC TO RESEARCH QUESTIONS	53
6.7.1	<i>Revisions to the Instruction Card and references to it</i>	53
6.7.2	<i>Language about the upcoming paper questionnaire and contacting the Census Bureau</i>	58
6.7.3	<i>Alternate version of the questionnaire cover</i>	59
6.7.4	<i>“Ramped up” language in Mailing 5</i>	63
7	CONCLUSION	64
8	REFERENCES	65
9	APPENDIX A: COGNITIVE INTERVIEW PROTOCOLS	67
Table 1. ACS Production and Strategic Framework Mail Materials		13
Table 2. ACS Strategic Framework Participant Characteristics by Round		19
Figure 1. Example from the production materials.....		13
Figure 2. Example from the Classic with a Twist treatment		15
Figure 3. Example from the Fresh Look treatment.....		15
Figure 4. Example from the To the Point treatment		16
Figure 5. Example from the Outside Researcher treatment.....		16
Figure 6. Commitment device in Classic with a Twist treatment.....		45
Figure 7. Commitment device in Fresh Look treatment		45
Figure 8. Commitment device in To the Point treatment.....		46
Figure 9. Commitment device in Outside Researcher treatment		46
Figure 10. Lower half of front page, Rounds 1 & 2		60
Figure 11. Lower half of front page, Round 3, Version 1 (original visual flow)		61
Figure 12. Lower half of front page, Round 3, Version 2 (new visual flow)		62

1 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report presents findings from the cognitive pretesting of redesigned mail materials that are mailed to respondents of the American Community Survey (ACS). The mail materials were redesigned as part of the ACS Strategic Framework Evaluation. The Strategic Framework was developed by the Census Bureau as a framework for evaluating ACS mail materials and developing new materials based on findings from relevant research literature (Oliver et al., 2017). The analytic framework was used to evaluate the various messages presented in the English-language mail materials in use by the ACS at that time (Schreiner et al., 2020). A cross-directorate team was formed to develop new mail materials based on the literature and informed by the analysis of production ACS materials. Part of this strategy involved selecting unique thematic messages to communicate in each of the five ACS mailings.

The Census Bureau's ACS Strategic Framework Mail Materials Design Team developed three new sets of materials, or treatments, to include in the 2021 Strategic Framework Mail Materials Test (2021 SFMMT). Each new treatment took a different holistic approach to conveying the suggested messages from the Strategic Framework evaluation recommendations. The Design Team had many ideas for changes that may be effective but no a priori reason to think one approach may be more effective than the others. These treatments were referred to as Classic with a Twist (CWT), Fresh Look (FL), and To the Point (TTP).¹ All three treatments focused on using plain language principles, including the standard language required by the Census Bureau, and incorporating the intended thematic message of each mail piece recommended by the Strategic Framework. In addition to the changes to content, the Design Team incorporated design features such as the use of color, icons, pictures, and novel structure. Each of the three treatments focused on using these novel features in a particular way consistently across mailings to highlight key information and thematic messages in each mail piece.

A fourth treatment, referred to as Outside Researcher (OR)², was developed by researchers outside of the Census Bureau³. They started with some of the earlier Census Bureau designs and stripped away some of the wording to create materials with minimal text in a traditional letter format. While these materials did not follow the messaging suggested by the Strategic Framework reports, they adhered to the principle that reducing text makes the materials easier to read, which was one of the guiding principles for the Design Team.

The newly designed materials were cognitively tested by Census Bureau researchers in the Center for Behavioral Science Methods (CBSM). The Design Team was interested in how participants perceived each of the four treatments. Specifically, the team was interested in how appealing they found each treatment, whether the use of plain language and novel design features increased readability and effectively highlighted the thematic messages, and whether each treatment increased the likelihood of responding to the ACS. Although the Design Team was interested in the performance of each treatment, the goal of cognitive testing was not to

¹ Treatments were renamed for a later field test. Classic with a Twist was renamed the Icon Treatment. Fresh Look was renamed the Sidebar Treatment. To the Point was renamed the Column and Header Treatment.

² The Outside Researcher treatment was renamed the Minimalist Treatment for the field test.

³ Judd Kessler from the University of Pennsylvania and Christine Exley from Harvard Business School.

identify which treatment performed best. All four treatments were intended to be used in a follow-up field test to assess their performance. Results of the field test can be found in Oliver, Contard, and Barth (2023).

CBSM's research team conducted three iterative rounds of cognitive testing with 63 participants. After each round, findings and recommended changes were presented to the project sponsors. The iterative approach allowed for changes made to the materials to be tested in subsequent rounds to evaluate whether they performed as intended.

The goal of the cognitive interviews was to answer the following research questions:

Questions about global design features:

- Q1.** *Does the use of color, images, and novel structure enhance the appeal of the letters? Does color affect readability or believability (perception of 'official' government mail)? (These features were only used in the CTW, FL, and TTP treatments.)*

Overall, participants reacted positively to the newly designed mail materials. Participants responded positively to the use of color, images, and novel structure in the letters. Any mention of the features affecting readability indicated that they improved readability. When explicitly probed, some participants did say that the use of these features made the mailing seem less official. However, many of these participants also indicated that other aspects of the mailing like the Census Bureau logo made the mailing seem official, so the novel features did not have a noticeable impact on believability.

- Q2.** *Do the strategies of reducing the amount of text and using plain language in the bodies of the letters improve readability and clarity of letter content?*

Efforts to improve the readability and clarity of the mail materials were successful. While there were no specific probes on the topic, interviewers were instructed to monitor for any indications that participants were having trouble reading or comprehending the letters. Aside from a couple of comments about one confusing sentence (discussed in section 6.7.2), participants did not indicate (explicitly or nonverbally) that the letters were difficult to read or comprehend. In every round, at least one participant from each treatment made spontaneous statements about the mailings being clear, easy to read, straight to the point, or understandable.

- Q3.** *Does Spanish messaging evoke any reaction?*

The use of Spanish messaging on the English-language letters did not evoke any particularly strong reactions during the cognitive interviews. Those participants that did comment on the messaging either made neutral statements noting that it was there, or positive comments acknowledging that the language would be useful for those who need it.

- Q4.** *Does including "OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope increase "believability" (M1 and M3 only)?*

The wording “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelopes of Mailing 1 and Mailing 3 did increase legitimacy. However, the wording was not always noticed by participants. Other features like the Census Bureau logo and a box on the envelope which included the words, “YOUR RESPONSE IS REQUIRED BY LAW,” seemed to draw most of the attention, increasing believability. Since the wording did not draw much attention in Round 1, the font was made larger and bolder before Round 2. This change succeeded in drawing more attention to the wording, but other features on the envelope continued to make more of an impact on legitimacy.

Q5. *Do participants think that the treatment is a cohesive package? Do icons or the column and header/bullet format improve readability (CWT/TTP)? How do readers react to the sidebar design (FL)?*

Since participants saw each mail piece back-to-back and only saw one treatment prior to the side-by-side comparison, it was hard to gauge the extent to which they thought the treatment was a cohesive package. Some participants did make comments, while looking at later mail pieces, noting that there are certain distinct features that would clue them in to the fact that they had received previous mailings if they received them spaced out in the mail. These comments were usually about the Census Bureau logo and the use of the color green.

Participants in the Classic with a Twist treatment generally seemed to like the icons and found them easy to read and understand. Participants in the Fresh Look treatment seemed to have a positive reaction to the sidebar. Participants in the To the Point treatment generally liked the column and header/bullet format of mailings and found the layout of this information easy to read and to understand. While there were a few comments about some of these features being unnecessary or not personally appealing, no one expressed strong negative reactions or indicated that the features would make them less likely to respond to the survey.

Questions specific to mailings:

Mailing 1

Q6. *Do changes to mailings intended to increase trust and legitimacy actually convey that to the reader?*

Participants tended to perceive Mailing 1 as legitimate. Multiple aspects of the mailing contributed to this; the most frequently noted ones were the Census Bureau logo, the director’s signature, the content in the FAQs, and the messaging on the outside of the envelope. There were no changes made to the Mailing as a result of findings from this research question.

Mailing 2

Q7. *Does highlighting community benefits resonate with the reader? Are they turned off by some benefits or conversely are they inspired by some benefits (enough so to feel that*

their response is important)? Does highlighting the use of ACS data by non-profit organizations resonate with the reader?

Highlighting the ways in which responding to the ACS can benefit the community resonated with a majority of participants across all rounds. Participants often commented positively on the community benefits while looking at Mailing 2. For many participants, this was the aspect of the mail materials that they said would actually motivate them to respond to the survey. None of the benefits listed evoked negative reactions. However, the use of ACS data by non-profits did not resonate with participants.

Mailing 3

Q8. *Does using messages about civic duty resonate with the reader? Or does reading about “jury duty” and “paying taxes” irritate the reader?*

The sentences about civic duty helped participants understand the importance of completing the ACS and why it is required by law. Participants generally liked the inclusion of the sentences. However, in Round 1, the phrasing used in the Classic with a Twist and the To the Point treatments was seen as a bit harsh. As a result, we recommended revising those sentences using phrasing similar to the sentences in the Fresh Look treatment. The revised phrasing performed well in Rounds 2 and 3.

Q9. *Does using normative messaging resonate with the reader?*

Participants’ opinions on the messages that reference members of the community responding to the ACS were mixed. While a few participants felt like the message would encourage them to respond, most reactions were neutral, and the messaging did not evoke strong reactions in any participants.

Mailing 5

Q10. *How does implementing a commitment device affect self-response? Does the commitment device make participants think they should circle or check an option and mail this piece back to the Census Bureau?*

The inclusion of a due date as a commitment device in Mailing 5 was a strong motivating factor to respond to the ACS. Participants felt that the due date created a sense of urgency and would prompt them to take action quickly. Participants also liked that the commitment device mentions three ways to respond, noting that the new option to respond by phone will be a positive to some people. While a couple of participants said the “select one” or “choose one way” to respond feature made it seem like they should mail it back, they said it was also clear that they were not supposed to do so.

Participants were randomly assigned to one of the four treatments. During the interview, participants were shown all five mailings in their assigned treatment one at a time and instructed to think aloud as they viewed the materials. Next, participants probed about reactions each mail piece (see Appendix A for interview protocol). After answering probes

about each mail piece, participants were shown all four treatments for selected mailings side by side. The side-by-side comparisons included think aloud technique and scripted probes.

In addition to the research questions used to guide the overall approach to the cognitive interviews, interviewers were trained to note and probe on any confusion or issues participants may have during the interviews. At times, the cognitive interviewing team noticed recurring issues that suggested a need to revise the mail materials. These included confusion about the purpose of the instruction card in Mailing 1 and messaging about how it was not necessary to contact the Census Bureau to request a paper questionnaire. Changes made throughout the rounds of testing lessened participants' confusion about these issues. We also tested changes to the cover of the questionnaire in Mailing 3 and language in Mailing 5 in response to recommendations from a National Academy of Sciences panel, convened before the third round of testing. The changes made to the questionnaire did not have a big impact. Participants were equally likely to prefer the original and revised versions. The changes made to the language in Mailing 5 successfully created a sense of urgency, which participants said would motivate them to respond.

Overall, the iterative rounds of testing confirmed that the treatments worked well to convey the messages outlined in the Strategic Framework. While the use of color, images, and novel structure diverged from the typical approach to mail materials taken by the Census Bureau for the ACS, our findings showed that participants still viewed the materials as legitimate and motivating. Post-round revisions ensured that all materials were in good shape for an eventual experimental field test.

2 INTRODUCTION

In an effort to increase self-response rates, reduce respondent burden, and reduce program costs for the American Community Survey (ACS), Census Bureau staff from the Decennial Statistical Studies Division (DSSD) and the American Community Survey Office (ACSO) developed the Strategic Framework project. The Strategic Framework project was a long-term multi-phase project that used a holistic approach to redesign the ACS Mail Materials. At the request of DSSD and ACSO, the Center for Behavioral Science Methods (CBSM) conducted cognitive testing of four treatments of newly designed mail materials as part of the project.

Researchers conducted three iterative rounds of cognitive testing on the mail materials to ensure all treatments were easy to understand and communicated intended messages. In each subsequent round, revisions were made to improve materials based on observations made in testing. Results of these cognitive interviews were used to produce the final versions of the Strategic Framework mail materials, which were experimentally field tested in September of 2021. This report presents the findings from the 63 cognitive interviews that CBSM conducted between November 2019 and March 2020.

3 STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

3.1 Overview

The Strategic Framework is a framework for survey messaging that was developed by researchers in DSSD and ACSO to evaluate the then current ACS mail materials (in 2017) and to develop new materials (Oliver et al., 2017). The Framework is based on best practices in survey communication and draws on findings related to theories of communication and behavior from various disciplines. The researchers used this analytic framework to evaluate all the messages presented in all the English-language mail materials in use by the ACS at that time (Schreiner et al., 2020). The mail materials included all letters, brochures, postcards, and envelopes used across five sequential mailings. The first and third mailings were envelopes with multiple materials, the second and fifth mailings were pressure-sealed reminders with three sealed perforated edges, and the fourth was a postcard (see Table 1). Analysts reviewed the materials and coded all the messages in the mail pieces, including symbolic messages such as the Census Bureau logo. The analysts organized the coded messages into four major categories: trust, benefits, burden reduction, and other. The Strategic Framework analysts concluded that the ACS materials presented too many messages to respondents; that some messages were repeated too often; that for some of the messages there was no evidence that they could motivate response to a survey; and there were messages that were proven to motivate a survey response that were not employed in the materials.

The Strategic Framework team next created a strategy for developing alternative mail materials based on insights gained from their review of relevant research literature and informed by the findings of their analysis of production ACS materials. This strategy emphasized a holistic approach by which the entire sequence of mailings is considered a continuous communication with respondents over time. Each mail contact would strategically present new messages to

appeal to different types of respondents and avoid unnecessarily repetitious messages. The new sets of ACS mail materials that would convey legitimacy and promote trust in the Census Bureau and use plain language principles to facilitate readability, comprehension, and retention of messages. A cross-directorate team was convened to develop mail pieces based on the Strategic Framework that could be tested in a planned field experiment using the ACS Methods Panel, called the 2021 Strategic Framework Mail Materials Test.

3.2 *Intended Messages*

The Strategic Framework prescribed a series of thematic messages that would be presented in sequence across five mailings (Oliver et al., 2017). The first mailing would focus on presenting the Census Bureau as a credible agency with a beneficial mission in order to build trust and confidence in the Bureau and establish the legitimacy of the survey request. The second request would highlight the benefits that the ACS provides to American communities, specifically in terms of providing useful data about communities to their leaders and decision-makers and linking those benefits to the recipient's participation in the survey. The messages in the third mailing were intended to reduce the perceived burden associated with the survey request by using normative messages and emphasizing the different response mode options and the availability of telephone assistance. The fourth mailing would reiterate earlier messages in order to promote retention and consideration of those messages and, since it is a postcard sent within days of the third mailing, served as a quick reminder of the survey request. The fifth and final mailing was framed as a last chance to respond to the ACS using a self-response mode or possibly be visited by a Census Bureau interviewer in person. The thematic message in the fifth mailing was a sense of urgency to respond via a due date.

4 MATERIALS

4.1 *ACS Mail Materials in the Strategic Framework Field Test*

The ACS Strategic Framework Mail Materials Design Team developed three new treatments to include in the 2021 Strategic Framework Mail Materials Test. A fourth treatment was developed by researchers outside of the Census Bureau using early drafts of the new materials developed by the Design Team⁴. Across all four treatments, there was a consistent focus on using plain language principles, including the standard language required by the Census Bureau. The three treatments developed by the Census Bureau's Design Team focused on incorporating the thematic message of each mail piece recommended in the Strategic Framework. Short messages in Spanish were included on the backs of Mailing 3 and the bottom of Mailing 5 to increase self-response from recipients whose primary language is Spanish. Unlike the original mailings (see Figure 1 below), the three treatments designed by the Design Team incorporated green in various ways. The color was chosen to match the shade of green on the ACS questionnaire and to maintain consistency across mail pieces and create a branded feel. Each treatment uses a distinctive visual design and messaging.

⁴ Judd Kessler from the University of Pennsylvania and Christine Exley from Harvard Business School.

When beginning to develop the three new treatments, the Design Team used the 2017 ACS production mail materials as a reference point.⁵ Descriptions of the 2017 ACS production and Strategic Framework mail materials and the dates each package would be mailed are included in Table 1 below. The production and Strategic Framework mail packages were similar in terms of the types of materials they contained, though some production mail pieces were removed in two of the Strategic Framework (SF) mailings. In the initial SF mail package, the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ) brochure and the multi-lingual brochure were removed (FAQs were added to the back of the invitation letter, and multi-lingual text was added to the instruction card). In the third SF mailing, the instruction card and FAQ brochure were removed, and the back of the letter contained instructions in Spanish.

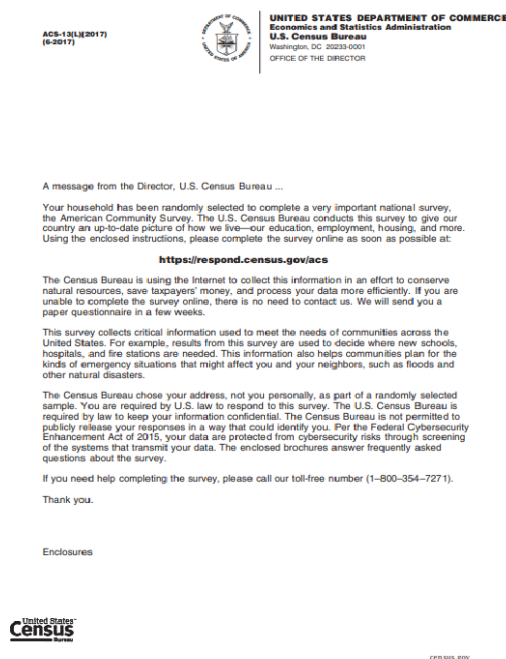


Figure 1. Example from the production materials

⁵ The 2017 ACS mail materials were no longer in production at the time of the subsequent Strategic Framework Mail Materials Field Test. The control treatment in the Field Test was the 2021 materials (see Oliver et al. (2023) for more information). The most significant difference between the 2017 and 2021 materials was a change to the fourth mailing postcard, all other changes were minor.

Table 1. 2017 ACS Production and Strategic Framework Mail Materials

Mailing	Timing and Universe	2017 ACS Production Mail Materials	Strategic Framework Mail Materials
1	Initial mailing, sent to entire sample.	<u>Initial mailing package</u> 1. External envelope 2. Letter 3. Frequently Asked Questions Brochure 4. Instruction card 5. Multilingual brochure	<u>Initial mailing package</u> 1. External envelope 2. Letter with FAQ on back 3. Instruction card with multilingual information on back (same across all treatments)
2	Sent about one week after initial mailing. Sent to entire sample.	Pressure seal reminder (grayscale)	Pressure seal reminder (grayscale)
3	Sent about two weeks after Mailing 2. Sent to addresses from which the Census Bureau has not received a response (as of mailing date).	<u>Questionnaire package</u> 1. External envelope 2. Letter 3. Paper ACS Questionnaire 4. Instruction card 5. Frequently Asked Questions Brochure 6. Business Return Envelope	<u>Questionnaire package</u> 1. External envelope 2. Letter with Spanish language instructions on back 3. Paper ACS Questionnaire (same across all treatments) 4. Business Return Envelope
4	Sent a few days after Mailing 3. Sent to all addresses who were sent Mailing 3.	Postcard	Postcard
5	Sent about 2 weeks after Mailing 4. Sent to addresses from which the Census Bureau has not received a response (as of mailing date).	Pressure seal reminder (grayscale)	Pressure seal reminder (grayscale)

Each of the following sections describes the four newly designed treatments. See Appendix B for all mail materials used in cognitive testing, including all revised materials across the three rounds.

4.1.1 Classic with A Twist

The “Classic with a Twist” (CWT) treatment was designed to be a clean-cut take on the original mailings. Mail pieces in this treatment had a more traditional look and feel, using the standard structure for letters. The “twist” in this treatment is the incorporation of clean design elements

and content structure intended to highlight information and simplify language. Whenever possible, plain language was used to convey the intended message(s) of each mailing using as few words as possible.

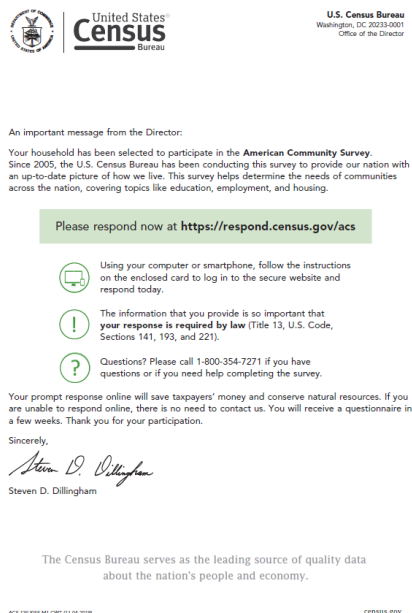


Figure 2. Example from the Classic with a Twist treatment

4.1.2 Fresh Look

The “Fresh Look” (FL) design was created to give a traditional letter a new graphical look and appeal. The distinguishing feature of this set of mailings is the use of a colorful sidebar placed to the left or right of the body of the letter. This design was inspired by the initial invitation letter used for the 1997 Economic Census in which a quote from Alan Greenspan, then-chairman of the Federal Reserve Bank, about the importance of the Economic Census to the American economy was presented in a sidebar. The sidebars in the Fresh Look mailings were used to highlight targeted messages, which allowed for reduced and more-focused text in the body of the mailing. The addition of the sidebar also reduced the margins for the body of the text, which was hypothesized to have the added benefit of making the body text easier to read. The sidebars were shaded green, except for the black-and-white

Visually, this treatment differed from the original mailings with the use of icons and the way that green was used. Each icon was designed to visually represent the adjacent text, quickly indicating the point of key pieces of information. Except for pressure-sealed mailings, which were limited to black and white, icons in all other mailings were green. In addition to green icons, this treatment also included boxes with a shaded green background to call out key information.

Overall, the treatment intended to keep each mailing as short and clean as possible to ensure recipients read the mailing in its entirety. Knowing that some individuals choose to skim mailings regardless of length, the visual elements were intended to increase the likelihood that individuals skimming the letter would be drawn to the information most likely to motivate them to self-respond to the ACS.

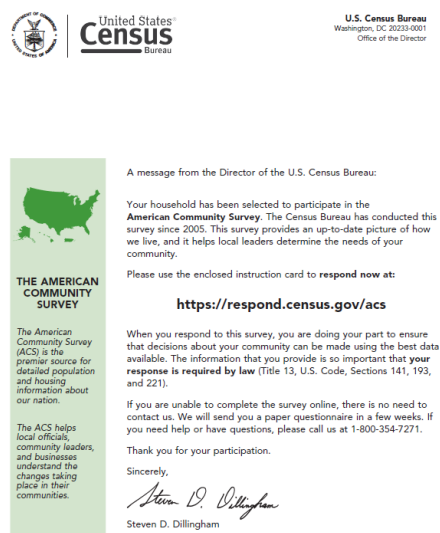


Figure 3. Example from the Fresh Look treatment

mailings, and contained colorful images such as a representation of the 50 States and Puerto Rico, silhouettes of small-town and city skylines, etc.

4.1.3 To the Point

The “To the Point” design (TTP) was based on a minimalist approach, allowing the reader to get “to the point” of the mail piece quickly. The distinctive visual element of the TTP mailings is the



use of two-column sections within the bodies of the letters to draw attention to concise, easily readable targeted messages. Two of the mailings presented headers in green. The headings have bold-printed text containing questions or topics hypothesized to be salient to participants, which are arrayed next to text addressing those points. This design was intended to approximate the effect of a Frequently Asked Questions document whereby salient topics are introduced and then addressed. The third mailing used a similar two-column section to present a short, bulleted list of ways that local leaders can use ACS data to address community needs. As with the CWT treatment, the instructions and the survey website URL were presented in a green-shaded box. The visual theme of headers in green text was repeated in the full FAQs on the back of the letter.

Figure 4. Example from the To the Point treatment

4.1.4 Outside Researcher

The “Outside Researcher” design (OR) focused on simplicity and repetition of main concepts to communicate clearly the most critical information to potential participants and did not incorporate novel visual elements. Compared to the other experimental letters, the content and structure of the OR letters was more typical of production ACS letters, though with significantly fewer words. The OR letters used brief, focused paragraphs that emphasized the mandatory nature of the survey, response mode options, the availability of telephone assistance, etc., with key text highlighted in bold print. Decisions on whether and how to incorporate recommended revisions to the OR treatment were left to the discretion of the outside researchers who designed the materials.

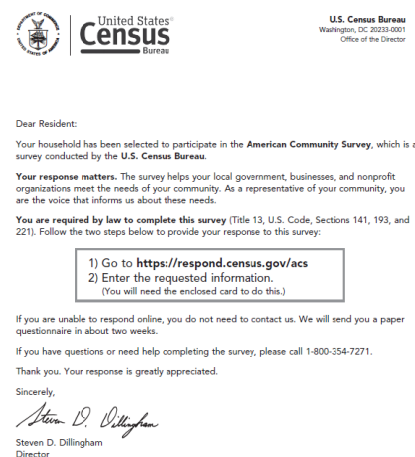


Figure 5. Example from the Outside Researcher treatment

5 STUDY METHODOLOGY

After the draft mail materials were created, we conducted 63 cognitive interviews in the Washington, D.C. metropolitan area from November 2019 to March 2020. Cognitive interviews were conducted by four experienced interviewers from the Center for Behavioral Science Methods (CBSM) who were trained on the cognitive interview protocol prior to testing. The goal of the cognitive interviews was to determine whether the newly developed materials were successful in communicating the messaging in the Strategic Framework, designed to increase response. We were also specifically interested in whether the design features in each treatment helped convey those messages and how those design features impacted readability and believability. Some research questions were about the design features across all mailings, while others were specific to individual mail pieces. There were no research questions specific to the Mailing 4 postcard.

Questions about global design features:

- Q1.** Does the use of color, images, and novel structure enhance the appeal of the letters? Does color affect readability or believability (perception of ‘official’ government mail)?
- Q2.** Do the strategies of reducing the amount of text and using plain language in the bodies of the letters improve readability and clarity of letter content?
- Q3.** Does Spanish messaging evoke any reaction?
- Q4.** Does including “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelope increase “believability” (M1 and M3 only)?
- Q5.** Do participants think that the treatment is a cohesive package? Do icons or the column and header/bullet format improve readability (CWT/TTP)? How do readers react to the sidebar design (FL)?

Questions specific to mailings:

Mailing 1

- Q6.** Do changes to mailings intended to increase trust and legitimacy actually convey that to the reader?

Mailing 2

- Q7.** Does highlighting community benefits resonate with the reader? Are they turned off by some benefits or conversely are they inspired by some benefits (enough so to feel that their response is important)? Does highlighting the use of ACS data by non-profit organizations resonate with the reader?

Mailing 3

- Q8.** Does using messages about civic duty resonate with the reader? Or does reading about “jury duty” and “paying taxes” irritate the reader?
- Q9.** Does using normative messaging resonate with the reader?

Mailing 5

Q10. How does implementing a commitment device affect self-response? Does the commitment device make participants think they should circle or check an option and mail this piece back to the Census Bureau?

5.1 Recruitment

We targeted participants who represented a variety of demographic characteristics (i.e., sex, race, ethnicity, household income, educational attainment, and age). Recruitment methods included the following: (1) advertisements through Craigslist.com and (2) a broadcast message distributed to all Census Bureau employees who work in the headquarters building in Suitland, MD and may have family or friends interested in participating.

Potential participants who contacted CBSM regarding interest in the study were administered a screener by telephone. The screener asked questions about a participant's demographic characteristics and the handling of the mail in the participant's household. We only recruited participants who handled the mail for their household or shared that responsibility with other household members in order to target the population of people who would interact with these mailings in real life. The cognitive interviews lasted approximately one hour and took place either at the Census Bureau headquarters in Suitland, MD or at a convenient location in the D.C. metropolitan area. Each participant who participated in the study received \$40 in compensation.

5.2 Cognitive Interview Participants

While we aimed to recruit participants with diverse demographic characteristics, there were nearly twice as many females as males in the sample. The majority of participants were either White or Black with a small number of participants identifying as either Asian, Middle Eastern, or two or more races. Eight of the 63 participants were Hispanic. The income distribution was close to being balanced across five income ranges. In terms of education, participants were almost evenly split between those with higher education (Bachelor's and Post-Bachelor's) and those without at least a Bachelor's. The age distribution was fairly balanced. See Table 2 for a more detailed breakdown.

Table 2. ACS Strategic Framework Participant Characteristics by Round

ACS Strategic Framework Participant Characteristics by Round					
		Round 1 (N=16)	Round 2 (N=20)	Round 3 (N=27)	Total (N=63)
Ethnicity	Hispanic	3	3	2	8
	Non-Hispanic	13	17	25	55
Race	White (non-Hispanic)	5	5	6	16
	White (Hispanic)	2	3	0	5
	Black or African American (non-Hispanic)	8	10	15	33
	Black or African American (Hispanic)	0	0	1	1
	Asian	0	1	3	4
	Middle Eastern	0	1	0	1
	Two or More Races	1	0	1	2
	Missing	0	0	1	1
Sex	Male	5	6	11	22
	Female	11	14	16	41
Family Income	Less than \$15,000	4	2	8	14
	\$15,000 to \$25,000	0	3	7	10
	\$25,000 to \$50,000	4	4	3	11
	\$50,000 to \$100,000	3	6	4	13
	More than \$100,000	5	4	5	14
	Refused	0	1	0	1
Age	18-30	3	4	6	13
	31-45	4	6	9	19
	46-55	3	2	6	11
	56-65	4	4	4	12
	Over 65	2	4	2	8
Education	Completed High School	6	3	4	13
	Some College, no degree	2	5	8	15
	Associate's degree (AA/AS)	0	2	3	5
	Bachelor's degree (BA/BS)	5	2	10	17
	Post Bachelor's degree	3	8	2	13
Treatment	Classic with a Twist	4	5	7	16
	Fresh Look	4	5	7	16
	To The Point	4	5	6	15
	Outside Researcher	4	5	7	16

5.3 Data Collection

At the start of the interview, participants were told they were going to look at some envelopes, letters, postcards, and the questionnaire that they would get in the mail if their address had been selected to respond to a national survey called the American Community Survey. Participants were given a consent form to sign. Interviewers briefly explained the content of the consent form before giving the participant time to review the form and ask questions. Interviewers explained that participation is optional, all information participants provide is confidential, and that the form also asks for their permission to have this session audio recorded. When applicable, interviewers informed participants that the interview was being observed.

Mockups of the mailing materials were used in the interviews. All materials were assembled as they would appear in production. For convenience, during the interviews, outgoing envelopes for mailings 1 and 3 were not sealed. However, the pressure-sealed mailings in mailings 2 and 5 were sealed and required tearing the perforated edges to open them. Participants were informed that mockups were being used for the interview and may not look quite as nice as they would if they received them in the mail. Each participant was initially shown materials from a single treatment.

Before showing the first mail pieces, interviewers explained the format of the interview. The participants were told they would be shown different mail pieces one by one. Interviewers handed the participant each mail piece vertically, pointing towards the participant to avoid impacting which side the participant looked at first. After they finished with a piece of mail, the interviewer would take it back and hand them the next piece, explaining each mailing as it was introduced. Interviewers asked participants to “think aloud,” verbalizing their thoughts as they looked at the materials (Willis 2015). During this portion of the interview, interviewers observed how participants interacted with the materials, noting which way the envelope was facing when opened, which sides of materials they looked at and in what order, and whether participants appeared to pay attention to the content (see Appendix A for observation checklists).

After participants had looked at all five mailings, interviewers administered a set of retrospective probes for each mailing. Interviewers handed each mailing back to the participant when asking probes specific to the mailing (see Appendix A). In addition to the scripted probes in the protocol, interviewers asked spontaneous probes in response to observations and comments made during the think aloud portion of the interview.

Once all scripted and spontaneous probes were asked about the mailings in the participant’s treatment, there was a side-by-side comparison of all four treatments for selected mailings. In Rounds 1 and 2, the side-by-side comparisons were done on Mailing 1 (letter only) and Mailing 4 (postcard). In Round 3, the comparisons were done on Mailing 2 (open pressure seal mailer) and Mailing 3 (letter only). The four versions of each mailing were shuffled prior to the interview and placed down on the table in varying orders. Participants were instructed to take a minute to look over the four versions of the mailing, thinking aloud as they did so. After participants looked over the materials, interviewers asked scripted and spontaneous probes

similar to those used in the previous portion of the interview. Interviews concluded with debriefing questions about their overall impressions of the mail materials.

It is important to note that one limitation of cognitive interviews is the back-to-back review of the mail materials. This may make features of the mail pieces stand out more than they would if they were received over a period of weeks in production.

5.4 Analysis

After each round, interviewers completed individual summaries for each of the interviews they conducted using a standard template. Personally identifiable information (PII) such as names were not included in the summaries and participants were referred to using ID numbers. Summaries included interviewer observations on how the participant interacted with each material (e.g., what they looked at and how closely they read the materials), think aloud feedback from participants, and responses to probing questions. Researchers also provided high-level responses to the research questions for each participant. All summaries were compiled into one document which researchers independently reviewed. We then held a consensus meeting to answer the research questions, summarize results, and agree on a set of recommendations for production materials. The compiled summary document and discussion from the consensus meetings formed the basis of the cognitive interview findings.

6 COGNITIVE INTERVIEW FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The sections outlining the research questions below (Sections 6.1 through 6.4.2) will be used to provide a brief high-level summary of findings for each research question across all three rounds of interviews. Subsections will then provide a more detailed discussion of each research question, presenting findings broken out by round.

6.1 Research Questions: Global Design features

- Q1.** Does the use of color, images, and novel structure enhance the appeal of the letters?
Does color affect readability or believability (perception of ‘official’ government mail)?
- Q2.** Do the strategies of reducing the amount of text and using plain language in the bodies of the letters improve readability and clarity of letter content?
- Q3.** Does Spanish messaging evoke any reaction?
- Q4.** Does including “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelope increase “believability” (Mailing 1 and Mailing 3 only)?
- Q5.** Do participants think that the treatment is a cohesive package? Do icons or the column and header/bullet format improve readability (CWT/TTP)? How do readers react to the sidebar design (FL)?

6.1.1 Research Question 1: Does the use of color, images, and novel structure enhance the appeal of the letters? Does color affect readability or believability (perception of 'official' government mail)?

Overall, participants responded positively to the use of color, images, and novel structure in the letters. Feelings about these elements seemed to be a matter of personal preference. Of those participants that commented on these features, more made positive or neutral comments than negative. Any mention of the features affecting readability indicated that they improved readability. Previous research has shown that mail materials for government surveys can effectively use color and images judiciously to catch the eye and draw attention to important information (Dillman et al., 1996; Leslie, 1997; Whitcomb & Porter, 2004; Hagedorn et al., 2014; Reingold, 2014). However, one study on ACS mail materials found that "colorful, image-rich, or friendly designs" were less likely to be perceived as coming from the government than materials with straightforward designs and typeface (Walker, 2014, p.14). Since the newly designed materials incorporate the use of color, icons, images, and novel structure, the Design Team wanted to assess whether these features impacted readers' perceptions of the new materials being official government mail. When explicitly probed, some participants did say that the use of these features made it seem less official than the version that does not use the features. However, many of these participants also indicated that other aspects of the mailing like the Census Bureau logo made the mailing seem official, so the novel features did not have a noticeable impact on believability. We continued to use novel structure and visual features in later rounds of interviews but made small changes to refine their use.

6.1.1.1 Round 1 Findings

Five of the 16 participants in Round 1 commented on the use of color in the letter during the think aloud portion of the interview. Three of the five made positive comments, one wondered why green was used, and one noted the color and said the letter didn't need to be "jazzed up." Two participants commented on the use of images or novel structure while thinking aloud – one positively and one negatively.

Four participants received the Classic with a Twist treatment in Round 1. Of the four, two participants commented on the color of the mailings during think aloud. None commented on the icons during think aloud. When asked what they noticed about Mailing 1, three participants made comments about it seeming official, being from Census, or from the government, conveying trust and legitimacy.

Four participants received the Fresh Look treatment. One participant noticed and mentioned the color during think aloud, but the other three did not. This participant seemed to respond to the coloring on the instruction card. During probing, one of the other three participants added that color was one of the first things they noticed. The two participants who commented on the use of images and novel structure were both from the Fresh Look treatment. One commented on multiple mailings saying that he liked the pictures and the sidebar. The other felt that the use of the sidebar made them less likely to read its contents. "The box over here on the side - the words are little, they're in italics, they're separated from the body of this - I didn't even look at them. They don't interest me when they're little and separated. My eye just kind of... my

brain sort of filters them out. I don't even see them, almost, like they're decoration or something," (Round 1, FL).

Four participants received the To the Point mail treatment. One participant commented on the color of the mailings during think aloud. "I liked the green color. There's green on all of them, but this one you really notice. And the reason I like it is because it makes it non-government looking," (Round 1, FL).

The Outside Researcher materials were in grayscale so there was no color to comment on. There were also no icons used in the OR mail pieces. However, one participant said that the fact that the instruction card has green was odd since the rest of the mailings are in grayscale.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the use of color, images, or novel structure after Round 1.

6.1.1.2 Round 2 Findings

Seven of the 15 participants in Round 2 commented on color when looking at the materials in their treatment. Four of them commented spontaneously during the think aloud portion, and the other three commented on color in response to probes. Six of the participants commented on the use of icons or novel structure (column and header/bullet format or the sidebar).

Of all of the comments on color, icons, and structure, all but one were neutral or positive. One participant who received the TTP treatment said she initially thought the use of green made the mail pieces look like junk mail during the think aloud. Once she opened it, she said it looks legitimate if you continue reading. The interviewer later probed on what she meant during think aloud.

"Just because I saw this beginning of this green box... that just kind of stands out to me and it looks like those refinancing and those surveys that get sent to your house every day... that don't hold pertinent information or anything... that doesn't really stand out to me as something that the Census would have... I would think they're asking for money," (Round 2, TTP).

None of the participants who received the CWT treatment commented on color when looking at the CWT materials. Only one explicitly commented on the icons. For Mailing 2, when asked if she noticed anything in the letter about why she should respond, this participant said that she noticed the icons with reasons on why to respond. She did not comment on whether she liked or disliked the icons.

Two of the participants who received the FL treatment commented on both color and the sidebar structure. When asked what she first noticed about Mailing 2, one participant mentioned the sidebar, "I noticed this little blurb on the side about the, it helps you plan parks and playgrounds and all that," (Round 2, FL). When asked what she first noticed about Mailing 4, she commented on the color green and the picture of the community. Another participant commented on the use of color tying the mail pieces together. When reading Mailing 3, a participant in Round 2 (FL) said, "All the color schemes are the same," and said this would help

him remember the previous mailings. He also noted that the green sidebar contained another reason to participate.

Four of the five participants who received the TTP treatment commented on either color or the use of the column and headers/bullets. In addition to the one negative comment on color discussed above, two others commented positively about the use of color. One noted the use of color in Mailings 1, 3, and 4, saying it drew his eyes to the green text or green boxes in each mailing. He also said the use of green throughout the mailings made it clear that they were related. During probing on Mailing 2, when asked if there is anything in the letter about why they should respond, three of the five participants mentioned the bullet points drawing their attention to the reasons. "Well, these bullet points, these are things I care about. And in fact, these are things that people complain about if they don't get," (Round 2, TTP).

As in the previous round, although the mail pieces specific to the OR treatment did not contain color, the instruction card that was included in all treatments contains green. One of the five participants who received the OR treatment in Round 2 commented on the color of the instruction card. Though he questioned the use of color, his reaction was neutral. "This is the only thing that has green - what's the point?" (Round 2, OR).

The use of color was spontaneously commented on much more in the side-by-side comparisons. All spontaneous comments on color during the side-by-side comparison were positive.

Round 2, TTP: "The colors make it seem more inviting."

Round 2, CWT: [Comparing CWT and OR] "[The color] makes me want to read the letter a little bit more. I'm more likely to read the letter than throw it away because it catches my attention."

Round 2, OR: "This one [TTP]. The color, the separation into the paragraphs [in the FAQ style]. This definitely makes it easier on the eyes."

When probed on if the side-by-side letters look like official government mail, participants commented that the OR version looked more official than the others, but that the ones with color still look official.

Round 2, TTP: "Honestly [OR] probably looks the most official because it's the most boring, but I think [TTP] is the most effective at communicating information and it still looks official enough."

Round 2, OR: "Yeah. I mean normally, I haven't seen official government mail that used color, I don't think I have. Normally there's not a lot of color. I mean maybe very little. But yeah, I mean it's still... usually what tells you that it's definitely official government mail is the envelope. I always feel that the most important thing is the envelope."

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the use of color, images, or novel structure after Round 2.

6.1.1.3 Round 3 Findings

As with the previous rounds, participants reacted favorably to the use of color, images, and novel structure in Round 3. Participants were much more likely to comment on these features during the side-by-side comparison than when they were looking at the single treatment.

Only one of the seven participants who saw the Classic with a Twist treatment commented on the use of color. She noted the use of color on the instruction card in Mailing 1. "I like the large font [on the instruction card]. I like how you used the little color to kind of bold to make things stand out. Because your eye just kind of goes right to that," (Round 3, CWT). Two participants who saw the CWT treatment commented on the use of icons, both reacting positively. During probing, one participant said the use of icons would prompt her to respond online. "I like whenever there's pictures to go with things because it kind of draws you to it, and you wanna see - 'Oh yeah, I really should do it,'" (Round 3, CWT).

Of the seven participants who saw the Fresh Look treatment, one commented on color and one commented on the use of pictures prior to the side-by-side comparison. The participant who mentioned the use of color commented on it for multiple mailings, even noting the lack of color on Mailing 5, the grayscale pressure sealed mailer. "This just isn't as easy as the others. The green makes it so much better. That green had the energy coming out of the letter. This one is just bland," (Round 3, FL). The participant who commented on the use of images said the picture of the family and the dog on the postcard (Mailing 4) resonated with her, making the mailing seem "kinder," (Round 3, FL).

Three of the six participants who saw the To the Point treatment commented on the use of color, with one of them also commenting on the use of bullet points. All three reacted favorably to these features. During probing on Mailing 4, one said, "I did like that it included the green. I don't know why, that just cues me in to that it's the same survey stuff," (Round 3, TTP). Another commented on the readability, "It's simple, green and white lettering, easy to read," (Round 3, TTP). This participant mentioned the use of color in Mailings 1 and 4 and lamented the lack of color in Mailing 5.

As in Round 2, one participant who received the OR treatment commented on the color green on the instruction card. During probing, he mentioned the color twice. One mention was neutral, just stating that he noticed the green on the card when he first opened the envelope. When asked if there was anything in the mailing that would make him more likely to respond he replied, "Definitely the green and the [URL for the] website," (Round 3, OR).

In Round 3, the side-by-side comparison was done with Mailing 2 and Mailing 3. Mailing 2 was grayscale, so analysis focused on mention of the novel features (icons, pictures, and structure). Sixteen of the 27 participants spontaneously commented on the use of icons and pictures during the think aloud portion of the side-by-side comparison of Mailing 2. All comments were either neutral or positive. Participants tended to say that the pictures helped draw attention to the benefits in the letter, or make the letter feel friendlier. While looking at all four pieces and thinking aloud, one participant said, "I hate to say this, but this [CWT] draws my attention. People like pictures. Even though I haven't read any of these. I think this one stands out a lot more," (Round 3, FL). When asked if one version of the letter would increase their likelihood of

responding, another participant said, "It would probably be this one [CWT] with the little pictures. Probably [because of] the icon type things. It sort of helps you read it faster with pictures," (Round 3, OR).

When comparing the four versions of Mailing 3, 13 participants spontaneously mentioned the use of color. All spontaneous comments about color were neutral or positive.

Round 3, OR: "The color does help. You sort of just jump to - if you just are scanning and you want to just jump to what you need to do, this one [TTP] seems like ways to respond, that's pretty straightforward there."

Round 3, OR: "These ones are colorful. I feel like [TTP] catches my eye first with the green text on the side and the green box. It makes it seem like it's easy to do and that they care about my response maybe. I think [OR] is the one I already read. It's a little bit boring. I don't think it mentions the technology, which I think is useful."

Round 3, CWT: "OR is not as appealing. The others have color. Green is [a] good eye drawer."

During probing, participants were explicitly asked if the mail pieces with color look like official government mail. In response to this probe, they were more likely to say they either do not look official or look less official than the OR version without color. Some participants said that even though the color looks less official, the pieces still seem official overall.

Round 3, FL: "I don't get a whole lot of official government mail so I couldn't tell you if it's similar, but I say without color, it's more official. And with color, it's a friendlier way for me."

Round 3, FL: "Yes. Because you do have the letterhead part - the United States Census Bureau. And then you have a little color down there, it's fine. Even though [OR] has the same thing, it doesn't do anything for me, it doesn't move me. You have the color, you've got that eye appeal, it makes me wanna read it."

Round 3, TTP: "Good question. Having the Census Bureau logo on top so you know it's government mail. As far as the green, I don't see why government mail can't be visually appealing. I don't think it affects it."

Round 3, OR: "Yes, they still do. I know a lot of government mail is not in color, but it still looks like it's very important to respond. It has the director's signature, the U.S. Census Bureau icon, office of director..."

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the use of color, images, or novel structure after Round 3.

6.1.2 Research Question 2: Do the strategies of reducing the amount of text and using plain language in the bodies of the letters improve readability and clarity of letter content?

Efforts to improve the readability and clarity of the mail materials were successful. While there were no specific probes on the topic, interviewers were instructed to monitor for any indications that participants were having trouble reading or comprehending the letters. Aside from a couple of comments about one confusing sentence (discussed in section 6.7.2), participants did not indicate (explicitly or nonverbally) that the letters were difficult to read or comprehend. In every round, at least one participant from each treatment made spontaneous statements about the mailings being clear, easy to read, straight to the point, or understandable.

6.1.2.1 Round 1 Findings

Participants in Round 1 appeared to read and comprehend the letters with ease. One participant expressed confusion about one set of sentences which was later revised for clarity (see section 6.7.2). There were no noticeable indications that participants were struggling to read or understand the content of the letters. Statements during the think aloud portion and responses to probes suggested that the content was interpreted as intended.

In addition to the lack of comments about confusion or difficulty reading, participants made spontaneous comments about the readability of the letters. Three participants in the CWT treatment, and two each in the FL, TTP, and OR treatments commented on the readability or clarity of the letters. Some of these participants made multiple comments throughout the interview.

Round 1, CWT: "I was able to read everything. The language was clear."

Round 1, FL: "I read it quickly. It's straight to the point, has all the info right here. This is cool."

Round 1, TTP: "They're easy to read. They make sense."

Round 1, OR: "Everything was explained and understandable."

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the amount of text or use of plain language after Round 1.

6.1.2.2 Round 2 Findings

As in Round 1, efforts to improve readability and clarity appeared to be successful in Round 2. There was another mention about a specific set of sentences in Mailing 1 being confusing. These were revised after Round 2. There were no other comments or non-verbal cues suggesting that the letters were hard to read or confusing.

Spontaneous comments were made about the readability and clarity of each treatment (one in CWT, two in FL, three in TTP, and one in OR). Participants referred to the letters as simple, straightforward, to the point, clear, and easy to understand.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the amount of text or use of plain language after Round 2. There was a separate recommendation to rephrase a confusing sentence after Round 2. This is discussed in detail in section 6.7.2.

6.1.2.3 Round 3 Findings

Round 3 confirmed the findings in the previous rounds. Since the confusing sentences had been rephrased, there were no comments about the content being hard to read or comprehend. Participants in every treatment spontaneously commented on the readability (four in CWT, one in FL, five in TTP, and one in OR).

Round 3, CWT: "Everything is easy to read, straightforward information."

Round 3, CWT: "It's very easy to understand for people."

Round 3, TTP: "I kinda like the format. That is very precise and it's easy to look at and understand. But the questions are good questions, questions I would ask."

In Round 3, one participant was a native Spanish speaker who was in the United States to improve their English. This participant read every mailing very closely. They were able to comprehend the content fairly easily. They only expressed difficulty one time, asking if they could use their phone to translate the word "due." The fact that a non-native English speaker was able to read and comprehend the mailings with relative ease is further proof that efforts to increase readability were successful.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the amount of text or use of plain language after Round 3.

6.1.3 Research Question 3. Does Spanish messaging evoke any reaction?

The team was interested in learning whether respondents had a positive, neutral, or negative reaction to the new use of Spanish on the letters.⁶ The use of Spanish messaging on English-language letters did not evoke any particularly strong reactions during the cognitive interviews. Those participants that did comment on the messaging either made neutral statements noting that it was there, or positive comments acknowledging that the language would be useful for those who need it. Since the messaging performed well without evoking any negative reactions, no changes were made to the Spanish messaging throughout the three rounds of interviews.

6.1.3.1 Round 1 Findings

Overall, the Spanish messaging was perceived well in Round 1. Nine of the 16 participants in Round 1 commented on the Spanish messaging while looking at the mail materials. Many of

⁶ The 2017 production materials included Spanish only on the instruction card.

these comments were about the instruction card in the first mailing, which was unchanged in the treatments.

Three of the four participants who received the CWT treatment noticed the different languages offered, especially Spanish, during think aloud, and the response was neutral to positive.

One participant who received the FL treatment commented on the Spanish messaging on the back of the instruction card during think aloud. Another participant mentioned all of the languages offered but didn't comment on Spanish explicitly.

Two participants who received the TTP treatment noticed the languages on the instruction card, but they didn't specifically mention Spanish. There were no negative reactions to seeing other languages on the materials.

Three of the four participants who received the OR treatment mentioned the different languages on the instruction card, but not Spanish specifically. Response was neutral – like simply pointing it out or saying it “doesn't apply to me” – or positive, such as liking that it shows multiculturalism.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the use of Spanish messaging after Round 1.

6.1.3.2 Round 2 Findings

As in Round 1, most reactions to the Spanish messaging were neutral, and a few were positive. The Spanish messaging did not evoke any negative reactions.

One of the five participants who received the CWT treatment commented on the Spanish messaging. During think aloud while looking at Mailing 1, they noted, “Oh, it's in Spanish.” The tone was neutral and matter of fact.

Three of the five participants who received the FL treatment noted the messaging. One of these participants noted it on Mailings 1, 3, and 5. The tone was neutral each time. “That part is in Spanish, oh it's in a couple different languages. Not [intended] for me,” (Round 2, FL). Another participant reacted positively. When asked what stood out to him about Mailing 1 he said, “It's helpful it has Spanish- a lot of people speak Spanish,” (Round 2, FL).

Four of the five participants who received the TTP treatment commented on the Spanish messaging. All four were neutral about the inclusion of the messaging. However, one participant thought that Mailings 3 and 5 should include other languages as well as Spanish to be consistent with the inclusion of multiple languages on the instruction card in Mailing 1.

Three of the five participants who received the OR treatment commented on the Spanish messaging. All three reacted neutrally, just noting that there was something in Spanish for those that needed it. As with the TTP participant mentioned above, one OR participant had an additional suggestion for the messaging. “The Spanish side of letter should mirror the English side. Like in Spanish, ‘if you have questions, please call this number,’ thanking them, signature, et cetera. When you typically get a form letter, the English and Spanish side are mirrors of each other,” (Round 2, OR).

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the use of Spanish messaging after Round 2.

6.1.3.3 Round 3 Findings

As in previous rounds, most participants in Round 3 did not comment on the Spanish messages. Those that did were primarily just noting that it was there. There were six neutral comments about the Spanish content on Mailing 1, three neutral comments on Mailing 3, and six neutral comments on Mailing 5. There were two positive comments about the Spanish message on Mailing 5. One participant mentioned that she does not need the message in Spanish, but she knows that her neighbor would if they were sampled. Another just mentioned that it was great that it is included as an option. There were no differences in the reactions to Spanish messages by treatment.

In Round 3, we did one interview with a participant whose primary language was Spanish. This participant read all of the materials closely and understood all of the messages in English. She noticed the Spanish language and said it was helpful. She understood that she could complete the interview in Spanish but said she would do it in English because she is in the United States to improve her English.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the use of Spanish messaging after Round 3.

6.1.4 Research Question 4. Does including “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelope increase “believability” (M1 and M3 only)?

Overall, the wording “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelopes of Mailing 1 and Mailing 3 did work to increase believability. However, the wording was not always noticed by participants. Other features like the Census Bureau logo and a box on the envelope that included the words, “YOUR RESPONSE IS REQUIRED BY LAW” seemed to draw most of the attention, increasing believability. Those that did notice the “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” wording when looking at the envelopes did say that it contributed to the legitimacy of the mailing. Since the wording did not draw much attention in Round 1, the font was made larger and bolded before Round 2. This change did succeed in drawing more attention to the wording, but other features on the envelope continued to make more of an impact on legitimacy.

6.1.4.1 Round 1 Findings

Four of the 16 participants in Round 1 made unprompted comments about the words “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelopes while thinking aloud.

Three of the participants who received the CWT treatment noticed “Official U.S. Government Mail” on the envelope and said that it did contribute to making the mailing look official. One of the three did not notice “Official U.S. Government Mail” until the third mailing, though. The fourth participant had not noticed that label and said it was too small to be noticeable.

compared to other things on the envelope. They still felt the mailing was legitimate, but for other reasons, like the Census logo.

None of the participants who received the FL treatment commented on the “Official U.S. Government Mail” on the envelope during think aloud. When asked during probing, three of the four participants said that they did notice the wording. Two of the participants that noticed felt that other wording/logos on the mailing made the mailing more official than this wording did, but the remaining two participants (one who noticed, and one who did not) felt that this wording did contribute to them considering the mailing as official.

One participant who received the TTP treatment commented on the “Official U.S. Government Mail” label during think aloud and said the envelope “looks official.” Two other participants also mentioned the mailing looked official during think aloud, mentioning other things like the logo or that it is from the Census Bureau.

None of the participants who received the OR treatment mentioned noticing this language on the mailing. However, during think aloud, one participant said they still felt the mailing looked official. When asked about the wording during probing, two participants in this treatment said the wording did increase the legitimacy of the mailing.

Recommendation(s):

Since not many participants saw the “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” wording in Round 1, we recommended increasing the font size of this wording and bolding it to make it more prominent. This change was incorporated for Round 2.

6.1.4.2 Round 2 Findings

Two of the 20 participants made an unprompted comment about the wording while first looking at the envelope. When asked if they noticed the wording during probing, an additional eight of the 20 participants said they noticed it.

Of the 20 participants, 11 indicated that the wording made the mailing seem official. The interviewer followed up with one of the participants who commented on the wording while thinking aloud by asking a probe about what she thought about the wording. She responded, “[This wording] makes it look more important. Also ‘Your Response is Required by Law’. I feel like I trust this box because it says, ‘Official U.S. Government Mail,’” (Round 1, CWT). Another participant said the envelope looked important. When asked what about it looks important, she said, “How it says, ‘Official U.S. Government Mail,’” (Round 1, FL).

Six gave neutral responses, with most saying that the other elements of the envelope would let them know it is official mail. Three participants made comments about how it did not mean much to them, including sentiments such as anyone can put that there or scammers try to make their mail look like official government mail: “Oh yeah, I saw. I think in today’s world, anyone can put that on there. This is the unfortunate world we’re living in. It’s hard to know who to trust,” (Round 2, FL).

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the envelope after Round 2.

6.1.4.3 Round 3 Findings

As in previous rounds, during the think aloud not many participants explicitly mentioned the “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” wording. In this round, only one participant raised this. During probing, six participants mentioned the “OFFICIAL U.S GOVERNMENT MAIL” wording as legitimizing or making Mailing 1 more official. When asked if there was anything about the mailing that would make her more likely to respond, one participant said, “The ‘official U.S. government mail’ part makes it look legitimate, but I would definitely double check. Some mail is not legitimate but tries to look like it is,” (Round 3, OR).

One participant seemed to think “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” did not really impact her, saying, “Thinking it’s junk mail. Throwing it to the side, and ‘I can get back to that later, there’s no rush,” (Round 3, FL). Overall, the “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” wording did not seem to have any negative effects as almost all participants seemed to find the envelope official and legitimate.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes to the envelope after Round 3.

6.1.5 Research Question 5: Do participants think that the treatment is a cohesive package? Do icons or the column and header/bulleted format improve readability (CWT/TTP)? How do readers react to the sidebar design (FL)?

Since participants saw each mail piece back-to-back and only saw one treatment prior to the side-by-side comparison, it was hard to gauge the extent to which they thought the treatment was a cohesive package. Some participants did make comments while looking at later mail pieces noting that there are certain distinct features that would clue them in to the fact that they had received previous mailings if they received them spaced out in the mail. These comments were usually about the Census Bureau logo and the use of the color green.

Participants in the Classic with a Twist treatment generally seemed to like the icons and found them easy to read and understand. Participants in the Fresh Look treatment seemed to have a positive reaction to the sidebar. Participants liked the sidebar because they liked pictures in the visual display (U.S. map in Mailing 1, community in Mailing 2 and 3) and they also found it informative on what the survey was about and how it would help the community. Participants in the To the Point treatment generally liked the column and header/bullet format of mailings and found the layout of this information easy to read and understand. While there were a few comments about some of these features being unnecessary or not personally appealing, no one expressed strong negative reactions or indicated that the features would make them less likely to respond to the survey.

Since the design features of each treatment were consistent across all mailings and did not change across the rounds, this section discusses how each treatment performed as a cohesive design overall.

Do icons or the column and header/bullet format improve readability (CWT/TTP)?

Overall, participants seemed to be able to read and comprehend both icon and column and header/bullet formats. In these next two sub-sections, we will explain each of them in more detail.

Icons in CWT

The majority of the participants generally seemed to like the icons and found them easy to read and understand. It seemed that some of these participants just liked pictures in general, as a couple participants mentioned how people are drawn to pictures. Some of these participants also implied that icons help them understand the survey and how the ACS would help the community (Mailing 2):

Round 1, FL: When referring to Mailing 1, "You know the question marks, it's telling you to say questions please call...and then they got [the] computer one."

Round 3, OR: When referring to Mailing 2, "I think the icons stand out as well. Even if I skip the part of reading [about] the local government [and] businesses, it tells you each icon and it says right next to it [started reading details next to icons]."

Some participants did not seem to like the icons as sometimes it was unclear to them what they meant, or they thought they came off as spam. "Nothing [here] that really gives you a punch with it...they don't have any significan[ce]," (Round 2, FL).

In Mailing 4, bubbles were used instead of icons with the words "how," "when," and "why" to provide background on the ACS and how to complete it. The majority of participants had a positive reaction to this postcard and a few participants mentioned this was easy to read: "Because it's telling me the how? The when? The why? very simply," (Round 2, OR). Overall, it seemed that participants generally seemed to like the icons and bubbles and understand their purposes and it was the most preferred design for Mailings 2 and 4.

Column and Header/Bullet Format in TTP

Participants generally liked the column and header/bullet format of the mailings and found the layout of this information easy to read and understand. They seemed to like the questions to the left and the answers to the right. When looking at Mailing 1, one participant said, "I like that it's in point format in the sense that it answers your questions before you have them," (Round 2, CWT).

There was not much negative feedback on the column and header/bullet format. Although the postcard (Mailing 4) did not perform poorly, participants generally did not seem to be as enthusiastic with this postcard compared to postcards in other treatments, making comments such as that it look cramped or jumbled. Overall, though, participants liked this design, and it was the preferred design for Mailings 1 and 3.

How do readers react to a sidebar design (FL)?

The majority of the participants seemed to have a positive reaction to the sidebar. Participants liked the sidebar because they liked pictures in the visual display (U.S. map in Mailing 1,

community in Mailing 2 and 3) and they also found it informative on what the survey was about and how it would help the community.

Round 2, TTP: “This one I liked because it explained to me about the survey. It even gave me a graphic of it, the survey.” (This participant is referring to Mailing 1.)

Round 3, CWT: “It’s telling me that this survey is really helping the community. I like the background; I like the pictures and the format.” (This participant is referring to Mailing 2.)

For the few participants who did not like the sidebar, one of the main reasons seemed to be that the text was too small. Another participant mentioned how the words were spaced together closely:

Round 1, OR: “The words are too bundled up, like too tight together. I really had to pause [and re-read] sentences like 3 or 4 times. I had to pause [and re-read] one sentence 3 or 4 times. The words [are] too cramped together. Well, not cramped together, but just doesn’t have enough space.” (This participant is referring to Mailing 1.)

However, the Fresh Look design with the sidebar was one of the more preferred designs for Mailing 3 among participants.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question.

6.2 Research question specific to Mailing 1

Q6. Do changes to mailings intended to increase trust and legitimacy actually convey that to the reader?

Participants tended to perceive Mailing 1 as legitimate. Multiple aspects of the mailing contributed to this, the most frequently noted ones being the Census Bureau logo, the director’s signature, the content in the FAQs, and the messaging on the outside envelope. There were no changes made to the mailing as a result of findings to this research question.

6.2.1 Round 1 Findings

When reviewing Mailing 1 initially, eight of the sixteen participants made unprompted comments about the mailing looking official. After reviewing Mailing 1, participants were asked retrospective probing questions about what they noticed when reviewing. Seven participants commented that it seemed official, either noting that it was from the Census Bureau or from the government in general. Three of these participants were in the Classic with a Twist treatment and two participants each were in the To the Point treatment and the Outside Researcher treatment. No participants from the Fresh Look treatment commented on this.

Participants mentioned many aspects of the mailing that helped with legitimacy, including the Census logos, director’s signature, content on the envelope, and the content in the Frequently Asked Questions section.

The FAQs were on the back of the letter and fourteen of the sixteen participants had looked at the back of the letter during the think aloud. Participants especially liked the FAQs, as they thought they were clear and answered any questions they may have.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 1.

6.2.2 Round 2 Findings

When reviewing Mailing 1 initially during the think aloud, seven participants made unprompted comments that the mailing looked official. Four of these participants mentioned elements on the envelope including the Census logo, stamp, and “YOUR RESPONSE IS REQUIRED BY LAW” language as making the mailing look more legitimate.

Two participants mentioned the mailing seemed legitimate when reading the FAQs; one participant was in the CWT treatment while the other participant was in the FL treatment.

One participant mentioned in the think aloud that the mailing initially looked like spam, but once she read it, she found it to be legitimate:

Round 2, TTP: “Initially it looks like one of those things that I see for a credit card, that they want you to sign up for a credit card. [...] It looks legitimate, so it's not... I don't think it's spam if you continue reading it.”

In retrospective probing, the majority of the participants found Mailing 1 to be legitimate. Ten participants mentioned the envelope and specifically made comments about the logo, stamp, “official business” language in the return address, and “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” wording.

Eight participants found that the FAQs helped legitimize the survey. Among those eight, four of these participants were in the OR treatment and two participants each were in the CWT treatment and TTP treatment.

Additionally, three participants said that the Census Bureau logo helped legitimize the survey. Of these three participants, one was in a CWT treatment, one was in the FL treatment, and the other was in the TTP treatment.

Three of the 20 Round 2 participants expressed mixed feelings on the legitimacy. Of these three participants, two participants said they would have to check online to see if it was legitimate, while the other participant said the inclusion of the FAQ, “Is this a legitimate survey?” would in itself make her question the legitimacy. Only one participant seemed to really question the legitimacy of Mailing 1 because she had never heard of the American Community Survey.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 2.

6.2.3 Round 3 Findings

In this round, participants did not make many unprompted comments during the think aloud. The changes to the letters seemed to help make the mailing look legitimate.

During the think aloud, six participants mentioned FAQs helping with legitimacy; three of these participants were in CWT, one participant was in FL, one participant was in TTP, and the other participant was in OR. Four participants (one from each treatment) also mentioned the fact that the mailing explains how responding helps the community added legitimacy and importance.

One participant in OR also mentioned the survey coming from the Census Bureau helped with legitimacy, while another participant in OR mentioned this would answer questions most people have. Another participant from OR said this was a professional document. Only one participant seemed to have a negative comment when looking at the letter during the think aloud, but that comment was related to the “required by law” statement.

During probing, participants generally mentioned some of the same features mentioned in the think aloud. Four participants mentioned the FAQs; one participant was in CWT, one participant was in TTP, and two participants were in OR. Four participants also liked the mention of communities and neighborhoods, with one participant in each of the four treatments voicing this opinion. One participant in the CWT group mentioned that she thought it was “survey spam” at first but then after reading it recognized the purpose of the survey was to help communities.

When asked what in the letters would make them more likely to respond, six participants mentioned helping the community or country (four of them in CWT, one of them in TTP, and one of them in OR), and one TTP participant mentioned the use of the color. Overall, participants generally seemed to have positive reactions to these features in the mail materials.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 3.

6.3 Research questions specific to Mailing 2

- Q7.** Does highlighting community benefits resonate with the reader? Are they turned off by some benefits or conversely are they inspired by some benefits (enough so to feel that their response is important)? Does highlighting the use of ACS data by non-profit organizations resonate with the reader?

Highlighting the ways in which responding to the ACS can benefit the community resonated with a majority of participants across all rounds. Participants often commented positively on the community benefits while looking at Mailing 2. For many participants, this was the aspect of the mail materials that would motivate them to respond to the survey. None of the benefits listed evoked negative reactions. The benefits that resonated most with a given participant seemed to be a matter of personal preference or connection. The use of ACS data by non-profits did not resonate with participants. Across all three rounds, only one person mentioned the use of the data by non-profits.

6.3.1 Round 1 Findings

Three participants spontaneously brought up the community benefits when initially looking at the mailing – one in the CWT treatment and two in the TTP treatment. For the participants who spontaneously brought it up, two mentioned parks and businesses, while the other brought up

that it “determined funding.” “I like that it's really explaining what the American Community Survey is. That it's going to help determine funding for local opportunities. I think that's great,” (Round 1, TTP).

During probing, participants were asked if they noticed anything in the letter about why they should complete the survey. Eleven out of the 16 participants mentioned community benefits in response to this probe (this includes the three who spontaneously mentioned benefits during the think aloud portion). The four participants in the CWT and the four in the TTP treatment all pointed out the community benefits in response to this probe. Additionally, two participants in the FL treatment and one in the OR treatment mentioned community benefits in response to this probe.

Participants did not indicate a strong preference for certain benefits, and no one mentioned anything they did not like. The words “it benefits the community” came up multiple times. Jobs, training, as well as infrastructure like roads and parks came up multiple times in the comments, as well as helping veterans and the elderly. Healthcare was also brought up by at least two participants: “For jobs and training, and highway and construction, and health care services. It's hard to get health care,” (Round 1, FL).

One participant felt strongly that the benefits in Mailing 2 would make him do the survey while nothing in Mailing 1 really encouraged him.

Round 1, FL: “Your answers help identify local needs such as job training, highway construction, and healthcare services. Did this... I didn't even read [Mailing 1]. Now I would go back to that and read. Because this caught my attention. Job training, highway construction, because these streets are a hot mess. So now I would pick [Mailing 1] back up and then I probably would log in to it. This would make me go do it. Because that caught my attention.”

Another was moved by the community aspect, explaining that while the benefits would not do much for him personally, he would be motivated to respond to help those around him.

Round 1, TTP: “Maybe your elderly neighbor that doesn't see well and can't do the survey, I'm doing it on her behalf to make sure she gets the services that she needs because they have the information. Because this stuff doesn't even apply to me. Parks and playgrounds, yes, because I have children, but everything else I get for myself. So, this doesn't really apply to me, but I know I have an elderly neighbor, I know I have a disabled neighbor. So, these things would benefit them. So, I would definitely take the survey. If not for myself, then for my community.”

One participant's comment when asked if any benefits spoke more to them than others summed up many people's feelings: “I feel like they're all kind of in the same range,” (Round 1, CWT).

Across treatments, the most prominent difference was that the benefits were missed by most of the participants who received the OR treatment. Only one participant in the OR treatment mentioned the community benefits when discussing Mailing 2. In response to the probe asking if they noticed anything in the letter about why they should complete the survey, this

participant mentioned the benefits as a secondary reason after the fact that it was required by law. When asked what he thought about the benefits, he said the language was vague and he did not think it was clear what the benefits meant.

In response to the same probe, two other participants only mentioned the fact that it is required by law. The fourth participant in the OR treatment said he did not see any reason to respond in the letter. When the interviewer pointed to the ACS benefit text, the fourth participant said, "Huh, I did read that. Yes, it did mention the reason why I'm taking the survey, but I think I was stuck on what was bold above it ['You are required by law to complete this survey']," (Round 1, OR).

The use of ACS data by non-profits did not seem to resonate with any participants; it was not brought up spontaneously or even during probing at all during Round 1.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 1. We continued to monitor whether highlighting the use of ACS data by non-profit organizations resonates with the reader.

6.3.2 Round 2 Findings

All but one of the participants mentioned the community benefits in Round 2 (this participant was from the OR treatment). Most of the comments were in response to the probe about whether they noticed anything in the letter about why they should respond. There were more spontaneous comments about the benefits in Round 2. All five of the CWT participants mentioned the benefits while thinking aloud. One in the FL treatment and two in the TTP treatment mentioned benefits while thinking aloud. None of the participants in the OR treatment spontaneously commented on the benefits.

Participants generally cared about each of the benefits equally. At least two participants mentioned parks being particularly important to them: "It mentioned how you can help your community and to build parks and community. That's actually a good reason. A lot of people are sympathetic, and this would encourage them to respond," (Round 2, FL). Another participant spontaneously said, "It helps them to determine where to put the spending dollars. Roads, operating local business[es], services for the disabl[ed] and veterans and the elderly, outdoor areas and recreation," (Round 2, CWT).

On the topic of certain benefits being more or less important, another participant said, "Well these bullet points, these are things I care about. And in fact, these are things that people complain about if they don't get. And probably most important, among the population, there's probably a range of opinions about what the government should and shouldn't do. I don't think anybody has a problem with these four things," (Round 2, TTP). No one mentioned having a negative reaction to any of the benefits.

While four of the five OR participants mentioned benefits in response to the probe about reasons to respond, several seemed confused about *how* the data would benefit their community. Most OR participants still mentioned the law as a primary reason to respond when asked. When asked if they noticed the part about community benefits one OR participant said,

"How?... it's kind of vague," (Round 2, OR). A second OR participant said, "If they had, even in [the first mailing] put in more details, let's say more concrete examples of how it helps.... [that would be good]." (Round 2, OR).

As in Round 1, the use of ACS data by non-profits did not resonate with any participants in Round 2. Two participants brought up confusion about the non-profit text. One participant was confused about how the Census Bureau was tied to non-profits and the other said the text and general idea was weird to him.

Recommendation(s)

All of the benefits other than the use of ACS data by non-profits still seemed to resonate with readers and having a mix of benefits seems to work well for the participants. Since mentioning the use of ACS data by non-profits had little negative impact, it was not changed.

We recommended that the OR treatment text draw more attention to the benefits by including specific examples. Participants were confused about "how" it benefits them more after reading this version than the others. The designers of the OR treatment chose not to implement this recommendation.

Between Rounds 2 and 3, the Strategic Framework Mail Materials Team presented the latest versions of the materials to a panel of experts at a National Academy of Sciences (NAS) meeting about communications for the American Community Survey. One recommendation from the panel was to change one of the benefits to refer to high-speed internet in order to appeal more to rural populations. As a result, one icon and benefit in the Classic with a Twist letter was changed from "Outdoor areas for recreation" to "Access to high-speed internet services." High-speed internet access was already listed in the TTP version of the letter, the other treatment that listed out multiple benefits in this format.

6.3.3 Round 3 Findings

Sixteen out of 28 participants commented on the community benefits in Round 3. Seven participants spontaneously mentioned benefits while thinking aloud (two in CTW, four in TTP, and one in OR). Fourteen participants mentioned community benefits in response to the probe asking if they noticed any reasons to respond to the survey (this includes two who spontaneously mentioned benefits as well). Five of the seven CWT participants listed benefits as a reason to respond. Three each in FL, TTP, and OR mentioned noticing community benefits as a reason to respond when answering the probe.

For the first time, a benefit that was off-putting to a participant came up. They said that "new businesses" can be upsetting if you are in an area dealing with gentrification. As in previous rounds, there was not a strong favorite among the benefits, and internet and healthcare came up several times in this round. Mentions of high-speed internet access were either positive or neutral. The change made to highlight high-speed internet access in the CWT letter performed well.

One participant spontaneously said: "So the difference from that one [pointed to the first mailing] [is] it's telling me it's helpful [for] working with your community and [getting] services

for [the] disabled, veterans, and elder[ly] people, and opportunities for local business and how to access high speed internet services,” (Round 3, CWT).

After being asked about the benefits, another participant said, "I think it makes a good point. It's very convincing. Like I really probably should fill this out because I want healthcare, hospitals, jobs in my area," (Round 3, FL).

Three out of seven participants who received the OR version felt the community benefits resonated with them. Two out of these three participants explicitly said the community benefits was not the first reason to respond they noticed when asked. One of them even said the letter needed to draw more attention to the benefits. Another participant who was not motivated by the community benefits was confused about what it means: “It's a little vague, I guess. In what way?” (Round 3, OR).

In Round 3, one participant mentioned the data being used by non-profits resonating with them. This was not a particularly strong reaction, but they noticed it and seemed to have respect for non-profits: "Yes, I see it. Because they're asking all this...[help] government, business, and non-profit organization understand the needs of our community,” (Round 3, CWT).

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 3.

6.4 Research questions specific to Mailing 3

Q8. Does using messages about civic duty resonate with the reader? Or does reading about “jury duty” and “paying taxes” irritate the reader?

Q9. Does using normative messaging resonate with the reader?

6.4.1 Research Question 8: Does using messages about civic duty resonate with the reader? Or does reading about “jury duty” and “paying taxes” irritate the reader?

The following sentences about civic duty were used in each treatment at the start of testing:

- CWT: “Responding is a civic duty much like paying taxes or responding to jury duty.”
- FL: “Just as the law requires us to report for jury duty, pay taxes, and earn a license to drive, it also requires us to respond to this survey.”
- TTP: “Responding to this survey is a civic responsibility-similar to voting or serving on a jury”

There was no civic duty message in the OR treatment.

The sentences about civic duty helped participants understand the importance of completing the ACS and understand why it is required by law. Participants generally liked the inclusion of the sentences. However, in Round 1, the phrasing used in the Classic with a Twist and the To the Point treatments was seen as a bit harsh. As a result, we recommended revising those

sentences using phrasing that is similar to the sentences in the Fresh Look treatment. The revised phrasing performed well in Rounds 2 and 3.

6.4.1.1 Round 1 Findings

Participants generally seemed to like the sentence about civic duty and seemed to understand the importance of completing the ACS when it is compared to other duties that are required by law. A participant in Fresh Look said the following:

Round 1, FL: "That's good. That makes it... I have never read anything like that. Now I would really sit down and be like ok, let me do this. Let's see what this is about."

Interviewer: "What about that sentence would make you do it?"

Round 1, FL: "Take it seriously? Because I see pay taxes, jury duty, and license to drive. So, they're basically stressing the point like it's really important to do this."

However, four of the eight participants in the CWT and TTP treatments felt that the language was a bit too harsh, even if they agreed that it presented examples of other civic duties. A participant in the Classic with a Twist treatment said the following:

Round 1, CWT: "Now that seemed to be a little intimidating... 'or responding to jury duty' if you're not a registered voter, are you still eligible to be on the jury? When I hear or read 'paying taxes', that's like if you don't pay your taxes, we'll throw you in jail or we'll penalize you. That's the part I would say, that's what I correlate with. If I don't pay taxes like... If I don't fill out this form, will they put me in jail?"

Recommendation(s):

After Round 1, we recommended considering revising the civic duty sentences in CWT and TTP to soften the language. We suggested the sentence that was previously tested by CBSM in a 2017 Mail Test as a jumping off point when starting to think of how to rephrase them (Martinez et. al., 2018). The sentence in the 2017 Mail Test materials read, "Just as people are required to report for jury duty, get a driver's license in order to drive, pay their taxes, and report their income, they also have the obligation to respond to this Census Bureau survey." The civic duty sentence in the Fresh Look treatment already used similar phrasing, so no changes were recommended for that treatment. In response to this suggestion, the following changes were made to the CWT and OR letters:

To the Point

Round 1 text: "Responding to this survey is a civic responsibility—similar to voting or serving on a jury."

Revised: "Just as we are required to report for jury duty, file taxes, and earn a license to drive, we are also required to respond to this survey."

Classic with a Twist

Round 1 text: "Responding is a civic duty much like paying taxes or responding to jury duty."

Revised text: "Just as the law requires people to report for jury duty, file taxes, or earn a license to drive, it also requires people to respond to this survey."

6.4.1.2 Round 2 Findings

As in Round 1, the majority of participants seemed to understand the civic duty sentence. Three participants mentioned that this message resonated with them; two of these participants were in CWT and one participant was in FL. Five participants interpreted this sentence to mean that the ACS is important or very serious. One participant in CWT said, “This made me feel even more so that it was important to do this thing and not discard it. Because if this was just as important as jury duty or filing taxes, then it’s important,” (Round 2, CWT).

However, as in Round 1, the civic duty sentence did not resonate with a few participants. Two of the 10 participants in the FL and TTP treatments found this off-putting; one participant was in FL and one participant was in TTP. Two participants said these other types of civic duties are not comparable to completing the ACS. One participant found this to be an empty threat, saying, “It doesn't seem like somebody is going to come and knock on my door and say you're under arrest for not completing the Census survey,” (Round 2, TTP). Another participant in CWT said, “How is this even compared to jury duty or filing taxes? Like that’s our duty as a citizen of the United States so, I feel like that’s something that I wouldn’t compare to a survey,” (Round 2, CWT). Overall, it seemed like participants understood this civic duty sentence and the intention resonated for many participants.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 2.

6.4.1.3 Round 3 Findings

Similar to Rounds 1 and 2, many participants seemed to understand the positive intention of the civic duty sentence. Eleven participants found this sentence to resonate or help them understand why the ACS was required; three of these participants were in CWT, four participants were in FL, and four participants were in TTP. Three participants said they understood the importance or seriousness of the ACS; two of these participants were in CWT and one participant was in FL.

However, as in the first two rounds, this did not resonate with a few participants. Two participants found this to be an empty threat; one of these participants was in CWT and the other participant was in FL. Three participants found this to be off-putting: one participant was in CWT, one participant was in FL, and one participant was in TTP. One participant, who was in CWT, said the duties listed are not comparable to completing the ACS.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 3.

6.4.2 Research Question 9: Does using normative messaging resonate with the reader?

Normative messages are intended to evoke normative beliefs, or “beliefs about whether important individuals or groups in a person’s life would perform the behavior and whether those individuals or groups would approve of them performing the behavior” (Oliver et al.,

2017, p.6). The following sentences are the normative messages that were used in each treatment:

- CWT: “Many households across the nation have already responded to this survey. We need your response too.”
- FL: “Millions of households participate in the American Community Survey every year.”
- TTP: “Many households have already responded. We need your response too.”

There was not a normative message in the OR treatment.

Participants’ opinions on the messages that reference members of the community responding to the ACS were mixed. While a few participants did feel like the message would encourage them to respond, most reactions were neutral, and the messaging did not evoke strong reactions in any participants.

6.4.2.1 Round 1 Findings

Participants’ opinions on the messages that reference members of the community responding to the ACS were mixed. This messaging resonated with a few participants positively when they were thinking about either the community or a specific group. One participant in CWT was thinking about their own community:

Round 1, CWT: "It's encouraging. It's like why should I allow another community to have the heads up or the... the clout or whatever? It's like they completed it, I don't want all of the federal funding to go to them, I want it to go to my community as well."

However, many participants seemed to feel neutral towards the sentence and did not have a positive or negative reaction. Some of the words and phrases participants used to describe the sentence included “ambiguous,” “redundant,” and “generic.” Another participant seemed to not think this sentence was true.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 1. We continued to monitor whether the use of normative messaging resonates with the reader.

6.4.2.2 Round 2 Findings

Participants were asked about their thoughts on sentences referring to ‘many households’ (CWT and TTP) or ‘millions of households’ (FL) completing the ACS. Although some participants found the sentence appealing, the majority of participants were neutral about this or did not seem to care about this sentence. Three of the five CWT participants did not care for this sentence, and three of the five TTP participants did not care for this. One participant in TTP said, “It wouldn't make me go 'oh my God my neighbors have done it, I got to get on it.' Because I don't care really if anybody else has done it,” (Round 2, TTP).

Of the four FL participants, only one participant seemed to not find it appealing. However, this still did not resonate too much. The FL participant said, “It’s a little bit encouraging that millions of households participate in it but that don’t necessarily mean I got to,” (Round 2, FL).

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 2.

6.4.2.3 Round 3 Findings

As in Round 2, the majority of participants did not seem to find the ‘many’ or ‘millions’ sentences to be appealing. Of the seven participants in CWT, four participants were neutral towards this or did not seem to care for this. Of the four participants asked about this sentence in TTP, two participants believed they should respond since others did but two participants did not seem to care. In fact, one participant in TTP mentioned in the debriefing that they were not sure why should it matter and why they should care. Of the seven participants in FL, four participants were neutral towards or did not care for it while two participants felt they should respond since others did. However, one participant said there was no need to respond if others did:

“Like I said, millions of households participated, so many people are doing it. Just me? They’re not going to miss just me. I’m sure plenty of people didn’t fill it out. They going to lock me up? What are they going to do?” (Round 3, FL).

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 3. The normative messaging was kept in because it’s a unique message that may apply to a different audience in the field test.

6.5 Research questions specific to Mailing 5

Q10. How does implementing a commitment device affect self-response? Does the commitment device make participants think they should circle or check an option and mail this piece back to the Census Bureau?

One recommendation for Mailing 5 from the Strategic Framework report (Oliver et al., 2017) was to encourage recipients to make a commitment to respond to the survey. The Strategic Framework Mail Materials Design Team chose to include a commitment device in each version of Mailing 5. The commitment device asks participants to choose or select which mode they will use to complete the survey by the stated due date. As shown below, each treatment used slightly different formatting for the commitment device. Classic with a Twist used icons depicting each mode. The Fresh Look treatment used the same general format as CWT, but without the icons. The To the Point treatment used check boxes next to each mode. The Outside Researcher treatment placed a call-out box around the device. The OR version used slightly different wording throughout the mailing. No icons or checkboxes were used in this version.

One concern with including the commitment device was that recipients may think that they need to respond with their answer. This was a particularly salient concern with the To the Point

treatment which included checkboxes next to each mode. For this reason, one focus for Mailing 5 during cognitive testing was noting any comments or indications that participants thought they may need to return the mailing after responding to the commitment device.

Classic with a Twist:

How will you complete the survey by **December 20, 2019?** (Choose ONE way.)



ONLINE: Go to **<https://respond.census.gov/acs>**
Log in with this User ID:



BY MAIL: Fill out and return the survey form you received in the mail a few weeks ago.



BY PHONE: Call 1-800-354-7271 to complete a phone interview.
Monday–Friday: 9 a.m. to 9 p.m.,
Saturday: 9 a.m. to 7 p.m., Sunday: 11 a.m. to 9 p.m.

Figure 6. Commitment device in Classic with a Twist treatment

Fresh Look:

How will you complete the survey by **December 20, 2019?** (Choose ONE way.)

ONLINE: Go to **<https://respond.census.gov/acs>**
Log in with this User ID:

BY MAIL: Fill out and return the survey form you received in the mail a few weeks ago.

BY PHONE: Call 1-800-354-7271 to complete a phone interview.
Monday–Friday: 9 a.m. to 9 p.m.,
Saturday: 9 a.m. to 7 p.m., Sunday: 11 a.m. to 9 p.m.

Figure 7. Commitment device in Fresh Look treatment

To the Point:

How will you complete the survey by **December 20, 2019?** (Choose ONE way.)

- ☐ ONLINE: Go to **<https://respond.census.gov/acs>**
Log in with this User ID:
- ☐ BY MAIL: Fill out and return the survey form you received in the mail a few weeks ago.
- ☐ BY PHONE: Call 1-800-354-7271 to complete a phone interview.
Monday–Friday: 9 a.m. to 9 p.m.,
Saturday: 9 a.m. to 7 p.m., Sunday: 11 a.m. to 9 p.m.

Figure 8. Commitment device in To the Point treatment

Outside Researcher:

How will you complete the survey by **December 20, 2019?** (Select ONE.)

- ONLINE: Go to **<https://respond.census.gov/acs>** and enter your 10-digit User ID:
- BY MAIL: Fill out the paper survey you received in the mail a few weeks ago and send it back.
- BY PHONE: Call 1-800-354-7271 to complete a phone interview.
Mon to Fri: 9 a.m.–9 p.m., Sat: 9 a.m.–7 p.m., Sun: 11 a.m.–9 p.m.

Figure 9. Commitment device in Outside Researcher treatment

The inclusion of a due date as part of the commitment device in Mailing 5 was a strong motivating factor to respond to the ACS. Participants felt that the due date created a sense of urgency and would prompt them to take action quickly. Participants also liked that the commitment device mentions three ways to respond, noting that the new option to respond by phone that was not highlighted in previous mailings will be a positive to some people. The aspect of the commitment device that asks them to “select one” or “choose one way” to respond did not have much of an impact on participants. Most did not comment on this feature and those that did were simply noting it was there. While a couple of participants did say this feature made it seem like they should mail it back, they said it was also clear that they were not supposed to do so.

6.5.1 Round 1 Findings

The most noticeable element of the commitment device seemed to be the inclusion of a due date. Thirteen of the 16 participants in Round 1 commented on the due date either during the think aloud or when asked what they first noticed about the mailing (four in the CWT treatment and three in each of the other treatments). Many commented that it was the first time they

noticed a due date in any of the mailings. Participants mentioned that the due date creates a sense of urgency. Some stated that they liked that they know how long they have to respond.

Round 1, FL: "Uh, oh. Due date. Now I'll take it seriously."

Round 1, FL: "It's the first thing I see, bold and big, it's not in color, but the shading catches the eye."

Only one participant explicitly commented on the fact that the letter was asking them to commit to responding via one of the modes. Round 1, TTP: "I don't really know the purpose of it. This is just... having somebody check they're gonna do something online. So they still could not do it? So what good is this paper? To me, it's kind of a waste of postage for you guys." No participants in Round 1 gave any indication that they thought they had to mail the letter back in after choosing which mode they were going to use to respond.

Most of the other comments on the devices were just noting that the letter mentions three ways to respond. Some picked up on the fact that responding by phone had not been offered in previous letters. "It's different because on this one they have all 3 options. It should have been on [the] first one. The only thing different is due [date] and giving all 3 of options. I didn't know about [responding by] phone until last minute. If I knew that at first, it would have been helpful," (Round 1, OR).

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 1.

6.5.2 Round 2 Findings

In Round 2 the commitment device evoked similar reactions to Round 1. The aspect that received the most attention was the inclusion of a due date. Seventeen of the 20 participants in Round 2 noted the due date either during the think aloud or when asked what they first noticed about the mailing (four in CWT, four in FL, four in TTP, and five in OR). Most comments were neutral, just noting it as they reviewed the materials. Others responded positively, indicating that they like the due date so they know when they need to take action by. A few participants said they wished the due date was included in earlier mailings.

Round 2, TTP: "Due date. That is the first thing I see. Yeah, that stands out in the upper left-hand corner."

Round 2, OR: "Oh, now I got a due date like a bill. I guess if you got the due date in the beginning maybe that would have kinda pushed you along to get it over with."

The second most commented on aspect was the fact that the commitment device listed multiple ways to respond. Some participants liked how the modes were presented in an easy-to-read format. Some participants also thought the modes should be presented in this format in an earlier mailing.

Round 2, FL: "I like the way this letter is set up. It tells you where online to go, the phone, tells you all the options that you can access the information. You should send this letter first probably."

Round 2, CWT: “The letter is straight to the point. It tells you what will happen if you don't respond, and it still gives you the options to do the other two. So, either responding online or by mail if you want to. You can also do it by phone as well. It gives you a lot of different options. It targets the whole population.”

Five participants explicitly mentioned that the letter is instructing them to choose one way to respond. Four of these participants were in the To the Point treatment that includes checkboxes. The fifth participant was in the Outside Researcher treatment. Three participants were just noting the language neutrally or saying that it specifies that you only have to respond using one mode. “The ‘one’ way is underlined so I don't have to do every single one,” (Round 2, TTP). The other two participants noted that the commitment device was a bit confusing because it seems like you have to let the Census Bureau know which way you are going to respond. Of these, one made it clear that he knows you are not supposed to send it back even though it looks that way. The other gave no indication that she thought she had to mail it back but did not explicitly say that she knows it is not expected.

Round 2, TTP: “One thing that's puzzling on here is because of these boxes, it looks like you're supposed to tear something off and send it back, and you're not.”

Round 2, OR: “It's a little confusing because it's asking to select one on how to complete the survey, so you have to tell the Census Bureau to complete it by phone, mail, online or not do anything so someone comes to the house.”

While there was some confusion mentioned, since no participants indicated that they would attempt to mail the letter back, no changes were suggested after Round 2.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 2.

6.5.3 Round 3 Findings

A smaller percentage of participants commented on the commitment device elements in Round 3, but the overall reactions remained the same. Nineteen of the 27 participants in Round 3 noted the due date either during the think aloud or when asked what they first noticed about the mailing (six in CWT, four in FL, four in TTP, and five in OR). Comments on the due date were mostly neutral or positive, saying that it was helpful or that it would push them to respond more quickly. One participant said that the due date would make her less likely to respond. She said this mailing seemed like a waste of time and that she would prefer to just wait for an interviewer to come to her house.

The inclusion of the different response modes was viewed favorably by participants in all treatments. Some noted that the newly included phone option would be easier for them, while others noted that they think that option would be helpful for older individuals.

Round 3, TTP: “They give you a lot of different options so hopefully one of these can accommodate somebody.”

Round 3, OR: “Huh, they come to your house. And then you can do it by phone. I don't remember if it said that you can do it by phone on the other ones. But that was a question that I asked you [after Mailing 3]. But it's nice. Lot of options. But maybe strange not to give you all the options to start with. I guess online collection is maybe the easiest for you guys as well.”

Three participants in Round 3 explicitly commented on the “select one” or “choose one” language. One just read it aloud and commented on the urgency. The other two noted it and indicated that their next step would be to respond online. “Choose one way. Okay - online! I will go to online and respond,” (Round 3, TTP). None of the participants in Round 3 gave any indication that they thought they had to send the letter back after choosing a response mode. Since the commitment device performed well with little to no confusion across all rounds, no changes were made.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 3.

6.6 Side-by-side comparisons

Q1. What stands out to participants in a side-by-side comparison of all treatments?

In the following sections, we describe features of the different treatments that stood out to participants. Overall, participants’ opinions varied based on their individual aesthetic preferences. There were few discernable patterns by treatment, although OR seemed to generate more negative comments than the other treatments. Color, format, and clarity of the text were frequent reasons given for liking a given treatment more than the others.

We note that the counts mentioned below are not mutually exclusive-- some participants mentioned multiple versions as standing out to them. In Rounds 1 and 2, the side-by-side comparisons were done on Mailing 1 (letter only) and Mailing 4 (postcard). In Round 3, the comparisons were done on Mailing 2 (open pressure seal mailer) and Mailing 3 (letter only).

6.6.1 Round 1 Findings

6.6.1.1 Mailing 1

A few participants said that the color green really stood out to them in the materials. They did not mention this in reference to a certain mailing, but instead just said that they liked it in the versions it appeared in.

Six participants mentioned liking CWT or the “icons” in particular. People felt the icons were great and one participant mentioned that it helps readers see where they needed to look for the necessary information to respond.

Most participants generally liked the sidebar and colors in FL. However, only three participants seemed to feel strongly that FL stood out in the side-by-side comparison, and two of them mentioned also liking another version (CWT and TTP) equally.

Six participants mentioned liking some aspect of TTP. They mentioned liking the discussion of benefits in TTP, and at least one participant said they felt it was the most official-looking. People liked the color and organization and said that the design was not “too much.” At least two participants mentioned that it clearly gives them the information that they need to respond.

Round 1, CWT: “I like [TTP] the most... I like the green contrast, the green and black. I like the green headers, 'Do I have to respond?' and 'Need a paper form?' more than the icons [on CWT]. It's more natural.”

Round 1, CWT: “[I prefer TTP] Because of the wording. It says your response helps the community plan for projects such as new schools, health clinics, playgrounds, for the elderly and veterans.”

The Outside Researcher treatment resulted in very mixed reactions. The majority of participants disliked it and felt it was too plain and said it did not particularly stick out in the side-by-side. The three participants who said it stuck out to them during the side-by-side felt strongly that they liked it. They felt it was more official and had less extraneous information. However, one participant expressed a preference for more color in OR,

“I think the strongest one so far is [OR] and I think that's because the two things in bold that catches your eye first are ‘your response matters’ and ‘you're required by law to complete the survey’...I like [OR], but I wish that there was color in it. I really like how all of these things have green,” (Round 1, CWT).

One participant who preferred TTP expressed a strong dislike for OR, saying that, “This one [OR] just sounds like they're trying to get information from you. They're not really planning on using it,” (Round 1, CWT).

6.6.1.2 Mailing 4

Many participants had a difficult time identifying which version they preferred or what stuck out to them for Mailing 4 because they felt two or even more versions were really good.

Four participants indicated that they prefer the CWT version for Mailing 4. Two of these people also liked another version equally. The other two participants mentioned that CWT grabs their attention and really sticks out from the others. An additional participant mentioned that although she prefers FL overall, the CWT version was the easiest to read and understand.

Participants felt more strongly about FL in Mailing 4 than they did in Mailing 1. Seven participants mentioned FL sticking out the most to them. Participants mentioned liking the “how/when/why” bullets and the layout with graphics overall. At least two participants mentioned that “we need your response” resonated with them. The green color also came up as something a participant liked about FL. One participant said they liked, “‘We need your response,’” the how/when/why bullets, and the ‘helping communities make informed decisions,’ [language]” (Round 1, FL).

Six participants mentioned TTP as sticking out to them. Reasons included the bold heading and the “either/or” layout that presents two ways to respond. As with Mailing 1, at least one

participant brought up that TTP struck a good balance between using graphics and not providing too much information. One of the participants did not feel strongly but they mentioned TTP as somewhat sticking out to them from the others.

As in Mailing 1, most participants felt negatively towards or did not mention anything in OR sticking out to them, but two felt strongly that OR was their preference. The two participants said that this was the best version because it was simple, and “stern” or official-looking.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 1.

6.6.2 Round 2 Findings

6.6.2.1 Mailing 1

Seven participants mentioned something about CWT sticking out to them; for the majority of them, it was the icons. Several mentioned the “how/when/why” format. One participant mentioned liking the icons in CWT the best but felt that OR was the easiest to read. Another reason given in Round 2 for liking CWT was the mention of “saving taxpayer money.”

Five participants mentioned FL sticking out to them, with most saying it was because of the side bar. However, another participant, who had no preference, said that, “I feel like it [the sidebar] makes it look less legit,” (Round 2, CWT). One participant really liked the “colored box” on FL.

Ten participants mentioned something about TTP that really stuck out to them, with the majority specifically mentioned liking the FAQ style. One of these participants was torn between TTP and CWT because he liked the pictures best. He said if that was combined with the “how/when/why” in CWT he would prefer that combination.

Another participant was intimidated by TTP but felt it communicated clearly: “Do I have to respond? Yes. This is intimidating. All of them [say it] is required by law but [TTP] makes it seem like you'll be trouble if you don't respond. It's more clear and to the point,” (Round 2, FL).

Three participants liked OR but a fourth specifically mentioned that they hated its lack of color. Participants gave the same reasons as previous rounds including that it is to the point, easy to read, and looks official. Several participants mentioned liking the box as a way to draw their eye to the information, but overall said they preferred the colored box in FL.

6.6.2.2 Mailing 4

CWT stuck out to nine participants, and it inspired both positive and negative views. Several participants felt very negatively about CWT; they said that it was too pushy and had too much information. One participant who liked it said they felt that it still was in danger of looking like spam because of the use of lots of color. As in previous rounds, participants mentioned liking the icons and the offset question format.

Seven participants mentioned liking the layout and/or pictures in FL. However, several other participants felt strongly that FL looked like spam and that the pictures were distracting.

As with FL, at least two other participants mentioned that TTP looked like spam and had too much going on. Two participants mentioned it sticking out to them in a positive way, however. One participant said they felt that TTP made them feel less of an obligation to complete the ACS than FL did.

Two participants strongly felt that OR was the best version because it was cleanest and looked official.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 2.

6.6.3 Round 3 Findings

6.6.3.1 Mailing 2

Nineteen participants mentioned CWT as really sticking out to them. The main reason given was the icons and visual layout of information. One participant pointed out how the icons quickly convey the needed information.

Eleven people mentioned something about FL that stood out to them. For most participants, it was the sidebar and how FL conveyed the importance of responding and reasons to respond. Other common reasons were the color and visual layout.

Six participants thought something in TTP stuck out to them. Reasons given were that it emphasized the benefits of responding and that they liked the reminder line at the top of the letter ("A reminder from the Director: Please complete the American Community Survey"). Several participants did not really say why they preferred TTP but just said it just stuck out to them in the side-by-side.

Four participants mentioned OR sticking out for its simplicity and for how it motivated them to respond. One of these participants said that while he preferred CWT, he was more likely to respond to OR.

6.6.3.2 Mailing 3

Only five participants mentioned something about CWT sticking out to them. For this mailing, it was mostly the icons. CWT was often mentioned alongside other versions that stuck out to participants, rather than as the only treatment that stuck out.

Fifteen participants mentioned something about FL sticking out to them. Most mentioned the layout and use of color, especially the images. One participant felt strongly the sidebar was distracting. Most of the fifteen participants both mentioned FL and TTP sticking out in a positive way to them.

Fifteen participants mentioned TTP sticking out to them, but most of these people also mentioned FL sticking out. The reasons given were similar to those given for FL, including that the color and visual layout grabs their eye. One participant mentioned how TTP is better if you just want to get the information and get to the point. Several participants mentioned that they liked the mention of community benefits in TTP. One participant said, "Because it's telling me why we need to respond for this survey because it's important to our community and our

nation and responding is required by United States law. Just as you're required to report for jury duty and pay taxes or earn license to drive- it's giving me a good example. So - more easy to understand," (Round 3, CWT).

Another participant pointed out that "response being required by law" was off-putting to her and said she preferred how TTP emphasized the benefits to your community as the reason to respond.

Two participants mentioned preferring OR for its simplicity and how official it looks.

Recommendation(s):

There were no recommended changes specific to this research question after Round 3.

6.7 Recommendations not specific to research questions

In addition to the research questions used to guide the overall approach to the cognitive interviews, interviewers were trained to note and probe on any confusion or issues participants may have had during the interviews. At times, the cognitive interviewing team noticed recurring issues that suggested a need to revise the mail materials. The following sections discuss recommendations that resulted from emergent issues or outside recommendations that were not tied to specific research questions.

6.7.1 Revisions to the Instruction Card and references to it

In Mailing 1, the log-in ID that is needed to respond online is located on the instruction card. There is language in the letter explaining this, directing participants to the card to locate the ID. In Rounds 1 and 2, many participants were not immediately sure what the point of the instruction card was. They realized that they would need the instruction card to log in, but still were not sure what specific information they needed from the card. After Round 1, changes were made to both the instruction card and the language referencing the card in the letter. While these changes were an improvement, there was still confusion around the purpose of the instruction card and the location of the log-in ID. Additional changes were made to the instruction card after Round 2, which resulted in a marked improvement. In Round 3, we saw a big improvement in participants both understanding the purpose of the card and being able to find the log-in ID. We recommended proceeding with the version used in Round 3.

6.7.1.1 Round 1 Findings

In Round 1, there were multiple instances of participants indicating confusion about the purpose of the instruction card included in Mailing 1. After coming across the instruction card, some participants who were confused by it went back to the letter in an attempt to figure out its purpose. They realized that they would need the instruction card to log in, but still were not sure what specific information they needed from the card.

During the side-by-side comparison of the four treatments for Mailing 1, one participant asked for clarification on the language discussing the instruction card:

Round 1, TTP: "I have a question. Why does it say 'Enter the requested information. You will need the enclosed card to do this?' First time I'm getting confused [by the materials]."

[The interviewer explained that the letter would come in an envelope with the instruction card that she saw in Mailing 1 and handed the card to her.]

Round 1, TTP: "Okay, so you gotta put in that or this? Why is that not here for these two [other versions of the letter]? Where are [participants] getting that with these two [versions]? So we've gone through this three times now, and I'm *just now* picking up on the importance of this card now, that you have to pay attention to the mailing [address label portion]. That makes me really feel like this center set up [in the Outside Researcher version] is the best. 'Enter the requested information. You will need the enclosed card to do this,' (emphasis added).

Other participants made similar comments during the side-by-side comparison of the Mailing 1 letters. They commented on the box in the OR treatment, saying it makes more sense than the other versions. Some said that the treatment they initially saw did not include the information that the OR version has that explains the point of the instruction card. All treatments did contain this information, but it was included in different places and used different phrasing.

Recommendation(s):

As a result of the confusion, CBSM suggested that the CWT, FL, and TTP letters should be redesigned so that instructions similar to the ones in the OR treatment are in the "box" area or formatted so that the explanatory text near the area stands out more. After additional discussions about the issue, the Design Team also revised the language on the instruction card to clarify its purpose and explain how to find the 10-digit login ID on the card.

6.7.1.2 Round 2 Findings

The changes made after Round 1 led to an improvement in Round 2. Eight participants made spontaneous comments that indicated they understood the point of the instruction card. There were no spontaneous comments indicating confusion about the point of the card.

While participants understood the point of the card, those that looked for the 10-digit ID could not always easily find it. Five participants attempted to find the 10-digit ID on their own during the think aloud portion and one was prompted to look for it by the interviewer after expressing uncertainty while thinking aloud. Four who looked for it did not find the ID before moving on. Two who looked found the correct ID. They both found it easily after counting the digits in the number they assumed was the ID. While they found the ID easily, they seemed unsure throughout the process and said that the ID needs to be more apparent. Since participants still had trouble locating the ID on the card, we recommended revising the instruction card to make the 10-digit user ID easier to find.

Recommendation(s):

The following recommended revisions were made to the instruction card to make the 10-digit user ID easier to find:

- 10-digit ID was made larger and bolded
- Revised the text explaining where to find the ID and removed “https://” from the URL (Note: The removal of “https://” was recommended by the NAS panel previously referenced)
- Round 2: HOW TO RESPOND: (1) Go to <https://respond.census.gov/acs> (2) Log in with the **10-digit user ID below**.
- Revised: HOW TO RESPOND: (1) Go to respond.census.gov/acs (2) Log in with the **user ID found in bold print below**.

6.7.1.3 *Round 3 Findings*

In Round 3, 12 of the 27 participants looked for or noted the ID during the think aloud portion of the interview without prompting. Of those, eight easily found the correct ID. "So just opening this up, looking at the card, pretty straightforward. Respond by going online to the [URL] and log on, User ID, pretty straightforward in bold, [Begins reading ID out loud.]..." (Round 3, OR). Four participants noted some uncertainty but eventually found the ID after counting the digits in the suspected number and/or reading that the ID was printed in bold. One of these participants looked through three sets of numbers before noticing instructions:

"It does say in bold below, but I didn't read that. I just went as far as go to the web site because that's how I would respond to it. If I had read carefully, then yeah it's pretty clear in bold below. That information is there. I just wasn't attending to it," (Round 3, FL).

For 10 of the participants who did not look for the ID unprompted during think aloud, interviewers probed to see if they could find the ID before beginning a newly added task that consisted of navigating to the website and attempting to log in. This internet task was completed by all participants who indicated that they would respond online (see below for more detail). Of 10 participants who did not look for the ID unprompted, nine were able to easily find the correct ID when asked by interviewers. The tenth participant looked for the ID but was unable to find it. "Let's see.... No, I did not look into the 10-digit user ID. Log in with the 10-digit user ID found on the enclosed card... [looks] Um, I'm still confused, so I am not sure which 10-digit one I should use. Yeah, because it's not very clear for me," (Round 3, CWT).

Internet task

In Round 3, we added an additional task to the interview to assess whether the changes intended to make it easier to locate the 10-digit ID worked. When individuals are sampled to respond to the ACS, the log in screen includes an image of the instruction card where the location of the 10-digit ID is circled and the text “Example User ID” is next to the image with an arrow pointing to the ID location. Since individuals would see this if they actually went online to respond, we wanted to see how navigating to the website impacted participants’ perception of the materials in Mailing 1. We also wanted to ensure that the removal of “https://” from the URL did not cause any difficulty navigating to the website.

The internet task was done after asking all probes on Mailing 1. If participants had not already indicated that they would respond to the survey online, they were asked if they thought they would respond online or go online to check out the website. All participants who indicated that they would either respond online or check out the website were asked if they would go online using their smartphone or a computer or tablet. If they said they would use their smartphone, they were asked if they were comfortable using their smartphone during the interview to do what they would do if they received the mailing at home. Participants who did not want to use their phone or who said they would respond using a computer or tablet were given a laptop for the task. The laptop screens were mirrored on a tablet for interviewers to watch as the participant completed the task. The text from the cognitive interview protocol is shown below:

➤ *If R said they would go online with their smartphone:*

Would you be willing to use your smartphone now and do what you would do if you were at home? *If yes:* Please do that now and try to think aloud and say what you are doing as you do so.

➤ *If no to smartphone or If R said they would go online with a computer or tablet:*

[Give R the laptop] Can you use this laptop and do what you would do if you were going online at home? Please try to think aloud as you do so.

Twenty-one participants attempted the internet task. Eleven of those used the laptop we provided and 10 used their own smartphone. Interviewers observed the participant completing the task and noted whether they commented on any difficulty, and whether they commented on the example image pointing out where to locate the 10-digit ID.

Navigating to the website

Two participants indicated difficulty navigating to the website prior to probing. One was unable to pull up the site, possibly due to a typo when entering the URL. The interviewer could not see the participant's cellphone screen to confirm what caused the issue. This participant was thinking aloud as she completed the task, so it was clear that she was attempting to type in the URL exactly as written.

The second participant who experienced difficulties did so because they added "www." before the URL, which results in a page that says, "This site can't be reached."

Round 3, FL: "I'm assuming it's www even though it doesn't say that. [Types in URL with www. and comments on error page.] Let me try it again. It has to be 'www,' not just 'respond by'...well let's try it. [Types in URL from card and successfully accesses page.] Oh, you don't have 'www'- I thought everything had to!"

All participants were probed on whether it was easy or difficult to navigate to the site. Only one participant said it was difficult. She was referring to not having internet at first on the laptop because the Ethernet cord was loose. This participant had no difficulty navigating to the website once the internet connection was fixed.

Attempting to log in

Four participants commented on difficulty finding the ID while attempting to log in. Three had not looked at the instruction card up to this point, the fourth (Round 3, CWT (mentioned below)) was the one who looked during the think aloud portion of his interview but could not find it when first prompted.

All were eventually able to “log in” during the task. We did not have test IDs for the task, so success was defined as typing in the correct User ID in the appropriate boxes. At that point, the interviewer stopped them and informed them that they had completed the steps correctly. During the task, two participants referred to the letter which pointed them to the instruction card, where they easily found the ID.

The participant (Round 3, CWT (mentioned above)) who had previously failed to find it earlier in the interview looked again after seeing the image on the website and was able to locate the ID. One participant never took the instruction card out of the envelope. He eventually found the ID by the barcode by looking through the address window on envelope. This participant did not mention noticing the image on the website but did read the text above the log-in box that read, “Enter the 10-digit User ID found below the barcode on the materials we mailed to you.”

Eight of the 20 participants who completed the task commented on the image of where to find the ID while thinking aloud when completing the task.

Round 3, CWT: “It actually has a picture of where you can find your User ID on it so that’s good.”

Round 3, CWT (mentioned above): “At first I did not understand, but now when you go there [it looks] so similar like I would look at this one then. Because it shows on there the example where I can find it.”

Individuals who did not mention the image while thinking aloud were asked if there was anything on the site that helped them figure out how to log in. Two mentioned the image.

Round 3, TTP: “If you don’t find [it] here [on the card] you can find here [on the website image].”

Round 3, OR: [Looks back] “Oh, yep. Didn’t even look at that! Maybe put that up higher for people like me.” [This participant completed the task on their smartphone, so they had to scroll to see the picture.]

Overall, the changes intended to make the User ID easier to find performed well in Round 3. The inclusion of the internet task provided some insight into how the instruction card and presentation of the User ID would perform in the real world. Although a few participants still expressed confusion about where to find the User ID when looking at the materials alone, all confusion was cleared up when those participants navigated to the website to log in and saw the image indicating where to find the User ID.

Recommendation:

No additional changes were recommended at this time. We recommended proceeding with the version of the instruction card used in Round 3 since we saw a big improvement in

participants both understanding its purpose and easily identifying the information they need.

6.7.2 Language about the upcoming paper questionnaire and contacting the Census Bureau

In Rounds 1 and 2, a couple of older participants expressed some confusion about a particular set of sentences in Mailing 1. The wording varies slightly across treatments:

Classic with a twist:

"If you are unable to respond online, there is no need to contact us. You will receive a questionnaire in about two weeks. If you have questions or need help completing the survey, please call 1-800-354-7271."

Fresh look:

"If you are unable to answer online, you will receive a paper questionnaire in about two weeks. If you need help completing the survey or have questions, please call 1-800-354-7271."

Outside researcher:

"If you are unable to respond online, you do not need to contact us. We will send you a paper questionnaire in about two weeks.

[paragraph break]

If you have questions or need help completing the survey, please call 1-800-354-7271."

To the point:

"If you are waiting to respond by paper questionnaire, you will receive one in about two weeks. You do not need to contact us. If you need help with this survey or have questions, call us at 1-800-354-7271."

The sentences are intended inform participants who cannot respond online that a paper questionnaire will automatically be sent to them; they do not need to contact the Census Bureau to request one. However, multiple older participants misinterpreted the meaning. One participant said, "You do not need to contact us. Okay, hmmm.... I hope this is all legit. All I see here is... United States Census Bureau. I hope this is legit. It says I can't contact them. Okay, so they chose me out of a hat, and then tell me I don't need to contact them," (Round 1, TTP).

Recommendation after Round 2:

The phrases "...there is no need to contact us" (CWT) and "you do not need to contact us" (OR and TTP) were the sources of confusion. The Fresh Look treatment did not contain either of these phrases. Therefore, we recommended replacing instances of this phrasing in CWT, OR, and TTP treatments with phrasing from the Fresh Look treatment.

Round 3 Findings and Recommendation:

There were no additional mentions of confusion in Round 3. We recommended proceeding with the revised phrasing pulled from the Fresh Look treatment.

6.7.3 Alternate version of the questionnaire cover

Between Rounds 2 and 3, the Strategic Framework Mail Materials Design Team presented the latest versions of the materials to a panel of experts at a National Academy of Sciences meeting on the American Community Survey. One recommendation was to revise the format of the front page of the ACS paper questionnaire. The original layout of the front page of the questionnaire created a “path” that draws the attention of the respondent to start reading at “You have two ways to respond...” (see figure 10 below). A panel member recommended re-designing the layout to change the path, drawing attention to the first box on the page where respondents begin filling out the paper questionnaire by writing in their name. The panel also recommended adding a tablet to the icons and wording about devices that can be used to respond online.

As a result of this recommendation, the Design Team revised the formatting of the front page of the questionnaire to change the visual path. The newly designed questionnaire cover was cognitively tested in a split-ballot design in Round 3. Half of the participants received a version of the questionnaire with the original flow, and half received the new version with the revised flow. While working on the redesign, the team identified a few additional areas for improvement. To ensure that the split-ballot design isolated the effects of the formatting change on the flow, these other revisions were applied to both the original version of the questionnaire and the new version. Changes made to both versions of the questionnaire included adding a tablet to the icon and wording (discussed above), adding “US” before “law”, and revising the “Contact Us” section (see figures 10-12 below for all three versions of the questionnaire).

Start Here

You have two ways to respond:



On your computer or smartphone:
<https://respond.census.gov/acs>

OR



Complete this form and mail it
back in the enclosed envelope.

The American Community Survey is
conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau.

**Your response to this survey is
required by law.** Federal law protects
your confidentiality (Title 13, U.S. Code,
Sections 9, 141, 193, and 221).



**If you need help or have questions
about completing this form, please call
1-800-354-7271.**

Telephone Device for the Deaf (TDD):
Call 1-800-582-8330.

¿NECESITA AYUDA? Llame al
1-877-833-5625.

For more information about the
American Community Survey, visit our
website at: <http://www.census.gov/acs>



**Please print the name and telephone number of the
person who is filling out this form.** We will only
contact you if needed for official Census Bureau business.

Last Name

First Name

MI

Area Code + Number



How many people are living or staying at this address?

- **INCLUDE** everyone who is living or staying here for more than 2 months.
- **INCLUDE** yourself if you are living here for more than 2 months.
- **INCLUDE** anyone else staying here who does not have another place to stay, even if they are here for 2 months or less.
- **DO NOT INCLUDE** anyone who is living somewhere else for more than 2 months, such as a college student living away or someone in the Armed Forces on deployment.

Number of people



**Fill out pages 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, and 7 for everyone,
including yourself, who is living or staying at this
address for more than 2 months. Then complete the
rest of the form.**

FORM **ACS-1(X)(2020)**
(02-20-2019) Draft 3

OMB No. XXXX-XXXX



Figure 10. Lower half of front page, Rounds 1 & 2

Start Here

You have two ways to respond:

Respond on your computer, smartphone, or tablet at **respond.census.gov/acs**

OR

Complete this form and mail it back in the enclosed envelope.

The American Community Survey is conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau.

Your response to this survey is required by U.S. law. Federal law protects your confidentiality (Title 13, U.S. Code, Sections 9, 141, 193, and 221).

Need help completing the survey?

If you need help or have questions about completing this survey, please call **1-800-354-7271**.

Text Telephone (TTY):
Call 1-800-582-8330.

¿NECESITA AYUDA? Si quiere responder en español llame al 1-877-833-5625.

Teléfono de Texto en español (TTY):
Llame al 1-800-786-9448.

For more information about this survey, visit our website at <https://www.census.gov/acs>

Please print the name and telephone number of the person who is filling out this form. We will only contact you if needed for official Census Bureau business.

Last Name

First Name MI

Area Code + Number -

How many people are living or staying at this address?

- INCLUDE** everyone who is living or staying here for more than 2 months.
- INCLUDE** yourself if you are living here for more than 2 months.
- INCLUDE** anyone else staying here who does not have another place to stay, even if they are here for 2 months or less.
- DO NOT INCLUDE** anyone who is living somewhere else for more than 2 months, such as a college student living away or someone in the Armed Forces on deployment.

Number of people

Fill out pages 2-7 for everyone, including yourself, who is living or staying at this address for more than 2 months. Then complete the rest of the form.

FORM **ACS-1(QX)SF-M3**
(10-03-2019) Draft 6

OMB No. 0607-0810
OMB No. 0607-0936



Figure 11. Lower half of front page, Round 3, Version 1 (original visual flow)

You have two ways to respond:

Respond on your computer, smartphone, or tablet at **respond.census.gov/acs**

OR

Complete this form and mail it back in the enclosed envelope.

The American Community Survey is conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau.

Your response to this survey is required by U.S. law. Federal law protects your confidentiality (Title 13, U.S. Code, Sections 9, 141, 193, and 221).

Need help completing the survey?

If you need help or have questions about completing the survey, please call **1-800-354-7271**.

Text Telephone (TTY):
Call 1-800-582-8330.

¿NECESITA AYUDA? Si quiere responder en español llame al 1-877-833-5625.

Teléfono de Texto en español (TTY):
Llame al 1-800-786-9448.

For more information about this survey, visit our website at <https://www.census.gov/acs>

Start Here

➔ **Please print the name and telephone number of the person who is filling out this form.** We will only contact you if needed for official Census Bureau business.

Last Name

First Name

MI

Area Code + Number

➔ **How many people are living or staying at this address?**

- **INCLUDE** everyone who is living or staying here for more than 2 months.
- **INCLUDE** yourself if you are living here for more than 2 months.
- **INCLUDE** anyone else staying here who does not have another place to stay, even if they are here for 2 months or less.
- **DO NOT INCLUDE** anyone who is living somewhere else for more than 2 months, such as a college student living away or someone in the Armed Forces on deployment.

Number of people

➔ **Fill out pages 2-7 for everyone, including yourself, who is living or staying at this address for more than 2 months. Then complete the rest of the form.**

FORM **ACS-1(QX)SF-M3**
(10-03-2019) Draft 6

OMB No. 0607-0810
OMB No. 0607-0936

Figure 12. Lower half of front page, Round 3, Version 2 (new visual flow)

With the split ballot design, half of the participants received the original visual flow version of the questionnaire in their Mailing 3 package and the other half received the new version. Interviewers noted any comments made about the front page of the questionnaire during the think aloud portion of the interview. Twelve of the 27 participants in Round 3 mentioned the questionnaire to some extent while thinking aloud. Two just noted that it was the paper version of the survey. One participant commented that they liked the style of the front and the use of bolding (Round 3, CWT V2). The other nine participants who mentioned the questionnaire commented on the fact that there are different ways to respond to the survey. Five of these participants received Version 1 and four received Version 2.

Round 3, OR V1: "On [the questionnaire], it says start here and it gives you options - smartphone, tablet. It also gives you the option to call 1-800. It says print name and phone number. It gives you TTY and both English and Spanish."

Round 3, OR V2: "You all have a lot of options. We can do this either paper or on the internet. That is awesome in my book."

A side-by-side comparison of the two versions of the questionnaire was added towards the end of the protocol, after the side-by-side comparisons of Mailing 2 and Mailing 3 in Round 3. During the side-by-side comparison, participants were instructed to think aloud as they looked at both versions of the questionnaire cover. Interviewers then asked probes about which version was easier to read and which would make them more likely to respond to the survey.

When asked if one version would make them more likely to respond to the survey, many participants said no, noting that they are similar. Of participants who did think one would be more likely to drive them to respond, there was an even split between the two versions. However, more participants said that the original version was easier to read. The most frequent explanation for the original being easier to read was that the use of the color places emphasis on what they need to know and directs their eyes. Participants liked that it drew their attention to the two ways to respond, saying that the new version would make them start filling out the form where they are supposed to print their name. That was the intention of the recommendation from NAS – to immediately draw individuals to the start of the paper survey. However, a main goal of the ACS communication strategy and the Strategic Framework is to get as many people to respond online as possible.

Recommendation(s):

CBSM advised considering what the preferred outcome would be (responding online or by paper) when deciding which version of the questionnaire to use in the field test. Version 1 with the original visual flow was used in the field test.

6.7.4 "Ramped up" language in Mailing 5

In response to another NAS recommendation, language in the first paragraph of Mailing 5 was revised before Round 3 to create a sense of urgency. This change was not made to the Outside Researcher treatment but was added to the other three treatments.

Ramped up language:

"Time is running out. We have sent you several requests to complete the American Community Survey and we have not received your response. You are required by U.S. law to respond to this survey. If you have not responded by Friday, April 24, a U.S. Census Bureau interviewer may visit your home to help you complete the survey."

There was some concern that this "ramped up" language may be off-putting, so we were particularly interested in how the changes would perform in Round 3. We did not specifically probe on the language, but the think aloud portion and more generic probes were deemed sufficient to assess whether the new language provoked any strong responses.

Twelve of the 20 participants who saw the ramped-up language in Round 3 either made explicit comments about the language or about the overall tone of Mailing 5 differing from the other mailings. Six of the 12 said the language or overall mailing created a sense of urgency, three

made neutral comments, two reacted negatively, and one said it created a sense of urgency but specified that it was a somewhat negative thing.

Round 3, TTP: "They're getting more... I wouldn't say aggressive, but it's more I guess intense...they're being more direct now."

Round 3, FL: "This is overly aggressive."

Round 3, CWT: "It's also telling me that time is running out and also that they have been sending me a lot of times this survey [sic], so I feel like I have to do this, even if I don't have the time, even though I'm not in a comfortable place to do it, or any other things."

Recommendation(s):

Participants are picking up on the intended sense of urgency in Mailing 5, which they say would motivate them to respond. Only a few participants expressed a negative reaction to the phrasing. We recommended proceeding with the language used in Round 3.

7 CONCLUSION

Overall, results from cognitive testing showed that the newly designed mail materials performed well. Participants indicated that the mailings were easy to read and comprehend. The mailings were successful at communicating their intended messages as outlined in the Strategic Framework. In Mailing 1, features such as the Census Bureau logo, director's signature, and messaging on the outside of the envelope worked to convey a sense of legitimacy. Mailing 2 was highly effective at highlighting the ways in which responding to the ACS can benefit communities. The benefits listed resonated with participants, with many saying they are one of the things that would actually motivate them to respond to the survey. The sentences about civic duty in Mailing 3 helped participants understand the importance of completing the ACS and understand how it is required by law. Mailing 4 did not have a unique message; it was intended to reiterate messages from previous mailings. The inclusion of a due date as part of the commitment device in Mailing 5 was a strong motivating factor to respond to the ACS. Participants felt that the due date created a sense of urgency and would prompt them to take action quickly.

While the use of color, images, and novel structure diverged from the typical approach to mail materials taken by the Census Bureau, our findings showed that participants still viewed the materials as legitimate and motivating. Feedback on the various design aspects varied, though a majority of comments were positive or neutral. Reactions to the design features seemed to be a matter of personal preference rather than an indication of a need to change designs.

Post-round revisions ensured that all materials were in good shape for the next phase of the Strategic Framework project. A field test was conducted from August 2021 through December 2021 to compare response rates across the ACS production materials and the four Strategic Framework treatments. See Oliver et al. (2023) for a full report on the Strategic Framework Mail Materials Test.

8 REFERENCES

- Dillman, D., Jenkins, C., Martin, B. & DeMaio, T. (1996). Cognitive and motivational properties of three proposed decennial census forms. U.S. Census Bureau. Retrieved July 14, 2023, from <https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2006/adrm/ssm2006-04.html>
- Hagedorn, S., Panek, M., & Green, R. (2014). American Community Survey mail package research: Online visual testing. U.S. Census Bureau. Retrieved July 14, 2023, from https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2014/acs/2014_Hagedorn_04.html
- Leslie, T.F. (1997). Comparing two approaches to questionnaire design: Official government versus public information design. U.S. Census Bureau. Retrieved July 14, 2023, from http://www.asasrms.org/Proceedings/papers/1997_056.pdf
- Martinez, M., C. M. Eggleston, J. M. Katz, and G. D. Morales. 2018. "Cognitive Pretesting of the 2017 American Community Survey Mail Design." Washington, DC: U.S. Census Bureau. Retrieved on April 23, 2021 from <https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2018/adrm/rsm2018-18.html>
- Oliver, B., S. Heimel, and J. Schreiner. 2017. "Strategic Framework for Messaging in the American Community Survey Mail Materials." Washington, DC: U.S. Census Bureau. Retrieved on May 6, 2020 from https://www.census.gov/content/dam/Census/library/working-papers/2017/acs/2017_Oliver_01.pdf
- Oliver, B., L. Contard, and D. Barth. 2023. "2021 ACS Strategic Framework Mail Materials Test." Washington, DC: U.S. Census Bureau. Retrieved on July 13, 2023 from https://www.census.gov/content/dam/Census/library/working-papers/2023/acs/2023_Oliver_01.pdf
- Plain Writing Act of 2010. 2010. Pub. L. No. 111-274, Stat 2861, 2862, and 2863.
- Reingold, Inc. (2014). ACS Mail package research: Focus groups and interviews. U.S. Census Bureau. 2014 American Community Survey Research and Evaluation Report Memorandum Series #ACS 14-RER-25
- Schreiner, J. P., B. E. Oliver, and E. A. Poehler. 2020. "Assessment of Messaging in the 2018 American Community Survey Mail Contact Materials." Washington, DC: U.S. Census Bureau. Retrieved on May 6, 2020 from https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2020/acs/2020_Schreiner_01.html
- Walker, S. 2014. "American Community Survey Messaging and Mail Package Assessment Research: Cumulative Findings." Washington, DC: U.S. Census Bureau. Retrieved on July

14, 2023 from https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2014/acs/2014_Walker_02.html

Whitcomb, M., & Porter, S. (2004). E-mail contacts: A test of complex graphical designs in survey research. *Social Science Computer Review*, 22(3), 370–376.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/0894439304263590>

Willis, Gordon. 2015. *Analysis of the Cognitive Interview in Questionnaire Design*. New York: Oxford University Press.

9 APPENDIX A: Cognitive Interview Protocols

Cognitive Testing of ACS Strategic Framework Mail Materials – Round 1

RESPONDENT ID #: _____ DATE: ____ / ____ / ____

INTERVIEWER'S NAME: _____

START TIME: ____ : ____ AM / PM VERSION: _____

Introduction

Hello, my name is _____, and I work for the Census Bureau. Thank you for agreeing to help us today. Let me start by telling you a little about what we will be doing today.

Every year, the Census Bureau conducts a number of surveys. Today we are going to look at some of the envelopes, letters, postcards, and the questionnaire that you would get in the mail if your address had been selected to respond to a national survey called the American Community Survey.

[If needed: Because these are example mailings, they may not look quite as nice as they would if you received them in the mail.] We will go through some different pieces of mail one by one. After you've finished with one piece of mail, I will hand you the next. I'll explain each one to you as we go along.

As I give you these mailings, I'm going to ask you to treat each one as you would if it came to your home. Please go through these as you would at home, as if I were not there, but say out loud what you are thinking as you look at the mailings.

I'm also going to ask you some questions about the mailings and about your reactions to them. There are no right or wrong answers. I really want to hear your opinions and reactions to these pieces of mail, so don't hesitate to speak up whenever something is unclear. Please feel free to be honest.

[IF OBSERVER PRESENT]: I want to let you know that this interview is being observed by other Census Bureau staff. They are observing the interview because they are also interested in how the mailings work for people like you.

Do you have any questions about what we'll be doing?

Informed Consent

- [HAND RESPONDENT COPY OF THE CONSENT FORM.]

Before we start, I would like you to read over the document in front of you. This document explains a little bit about this interview and provides information about your rights as a respondent, such as that your participation is optional, all information you provide is confidential, and we won't use your name in any report. It also asks for your permission to have this session audio (if applicable: and video) recorded so that I can concentrate on what you are saying rather than having to take extensive notes. Please ask me any questions you have about this document. Once you have finished reading the document, please sign and date it.

- [RESPONDENT READS FORM THEN SIGNS AND DATES FORM]

Thank you for signing the consent form. I will also sign this form to show that I agree to everything in the form.

- [INTERVIEWER SIGNS AND DATES FORM]
- [IF RESPONDENT PROVIDES CONSENT TO HAVE THE SESSION RECORDED]: I will now turn on the recorder.
- [TURN ON RECORDER]

Think-Aloud

While you are looking at the materials I give you, I'd like you to tell me what's going through your mind. This could include what information you're seeing in each material, questions that come to your mind, and reactions you're having. You do not have to read aloud if you would not do that at home.

No practice for think aloud. Encourage respondents to think aloud as needed throughout interview, especially with first few mailing pieces:

- What are you looking at?
- What are you thinking?
- Remember to tell me what you are thinking about as you look at these mailings.

Observation

Research Questions:

1. Does the use of color, images, and novel structure enhance the appeal of the letters?
2. Do the strategies of reducing the amount of text and using plain language in the bodies of the letters improve readability and clarity of letter content?
3. Does including "OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope increase "believability"?
4. Do reducing text, using plain language, and the use of novel visual design elements make the letters look too "unofficial"?
5. Does Spanish messaging evoke any reaction?

Okay, let's get started.

- Make observation notes below (see questions in red text). Note any nonverbal reactions.
- If respondent indicates that they would not look at a piece of mail/would let mail pile up, note that but then ask them to look at it anyway.
- Let the respondent spend no more than 5 minutes looking at each mailing.
- Take back each mailing after respondent is finished with it—do not let them compare the mailings to each other until specified.
- Hand materials to respondents **SIDEWAYS**, so that it is neither face up or face down.

Mailing 1 - initial letter: Okay, let's get started. Imagine you received this piece of mail at your house. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R comment on "OFFICIAL US GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope?

___ Yes ___ No

If yes, what did they say? _____

2. Which way does R take materials out of the envelope?

___ Address side up ___ Address side down

3. What materials does R look at, and in what order? Mark "X" if respondent did not look at a material. Otherwise put a number to indicate the order.

___ Envelope, front ___ Envelope, back ___ Letter, front

___ Letter, back ___ Instruction card, front ___ Instruction card, back

4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

___ Yes, legitimate ___ Yes, unofficial ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

5. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

6. Does R comment on the coloring used?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

7. Does R comment on response being required?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

8. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, what did they say? _____

9. Does R read letter front; if so, how closely?

___ Did not look ___ Glanced ___ Skimmed ___ Read closely

10. Does R read FAQs on back of letter; if so, how closely?

___ Did not look ___ Glanced ___ Skimmed ___ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Note any comments R had on the back of the letter:

Other notes

Mailing 2 - first reminder letter, pressure seal: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you would receive a few days later. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Which way does R open pressure seal?

☐ Address side up ☐ Address side down

2. Does R look at both sides (address side and blank side)?

☐ Yes ☐ No

3. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

☐ Yes, legitimate ☐ Yes, unofficial ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces looks like it belongs with previous mailings?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment on? : _____

5. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

6. Does R make any unprompted comments about the community benefits mentioned in the letter?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment? : _____

7. Does R comment on the uses of the ACS data?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment? : _____

8. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

9. Does R read content inside pressure seal; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Mailing 3 - paper questionnaire package: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you *might* receive about a week later. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R comment on "OFFICIAL US GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope?

☐ Yes ☐ No

If yes, what did they say? _____

2. Which way does R take materials out of the envelope?

☐ Address side up ☐ Address side down

3. What materials does R look at, and in what order? Mark "X" if respondent did not look at a material. Otherwise, put a number to indicate the order.

☐ Outer envelope, front ☐ Outer envelope, back ☐ Letter, front ☐ Letter, back

☐ Questionnaire ☐ Return envelope, front ☐ Return envelope, back

4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

☐ Yes, legitimate ☐ Yes, unofficial ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

5. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

6. Does R comment on the coloring used?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

7. Does R make unprompted comments about the text about civic duty?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment? : _____

8. Does R make unprompted comments on the line about millions of households/many households completing survey?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment? : _____

9. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

10. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they say? _____

11. Does R read letter front? If so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Note any comments R had on the back of the letter:

Other notes:

Mailing 4 - postcard: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you *might* receive a few days later. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R look at both sides?

☐ Yes ☐ No

2. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

☐ Yes, legitimate ☐ Yes, unofficial ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

3. (Only in the 'Classic With a Twist' treatment) Does R comment on the bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

4. Does R comment on the coloring used?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

5. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment on: _____

6. Does R read content; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Mailing 5 – final reminder, pressure seal: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you would receive a few days later. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Which way does R open pressure seal?

☐ Address side up ☐ Address side down

2. Does R look at both sides (address side and blank side)?

☐ Yes ☐ No

3. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

4. Does R comment on the due date?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment?: _____

5. Does R comment on the commitment device?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment?: _____

6. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

7. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they say? _____

8. Does R read content inside pressure seal; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Probing

Thank you. Now I have a few questions I'd like to ask you about the mailings.

- Only ask probe if not mentioned during think aloud.
- Take back each mailing after respondent is finished with it—do not let them compare the mailings to each other until specified.
- Hand materials to respondents SIDEWAYS, so that it is neither face up or face down.

Mailing 1 - initial letter:

Research Questions:

1. Does including “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelope increase “believability”?
2. Do changes to mailings intended to increase trust and legitimacy actually convey that to the reader? (i.e., adding FAQs about the survey, highlighting the Census logo, testimonies on back of letters from credible experts, using consistent coloring throughout mailings)

This is the first mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. *If needed:* When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. What do you think the main point of this mailing is?
3. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
4. *If needed:* After getting this letter, would you respond to the survey? Tell me more about that.
5. *If needed:* Do you think you have to respond to the survey?
6. *If needed:* Did you notice the back of this letter? What do you think about it?

Now let's take a look at the envelope.

1. *If R didn't comment on the wording during observation:* Did you notice this wording on this envelope? [Point to 'Official U.S. Government Mail']
2. What do you think about this wording? *If needed:* Would this make you more or less likely to open up the envelope?

Mailing 2 - first reminder pressure seal:

Research Questions:

1. Does highlighting community benefits resonate with the reader?
2. Are they turned off by some benefits or conversely are they inspired by some benefits (enough so to feel that their response is important)?
3. Does highlighting the use of ACS data by non-profit organizations resonate with the reader?
4. [Classic w/a Twist and To The Point] Does including a “Reminder...” line in the top row of the second letter make the letter seem more friendly... less demanding?

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the second mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. *If needed:* When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. What do you think the main point of this mailing is?
3. Did this seem the same as the first mailing, or did it seem different? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
4. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
5. If you hadn't responded already, after getting this letter do you think you would respond to the survey?
6. **[IF PARTICIPANT ADMINISTERED CLASSIC WITH A TWIST OR TO THE POINT]** Please read the first line of the letter that says "Reminder". Did you notice this sentence when reading the letter? What do you think about this reminder? *If needed:* Do you think this reminder is helpful?
7. *If needed:* Did you notice anything in the letter about why you should complete the survey? Tell me more that.
 - a. *If participant mentioned the benefits or use of ACS data:* What do you think about that?
 - b. *If participant did not mention the benefits or use of ACS data :* **[POINT TO THE APPLICABLE SECTIONS ON BENEFITS AND USES OF DATA]** Please read this section(s). What do you think about this part of the letter?

Mailing 3 - paper questionnaire package:

Research Questions:

1. Does including "OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope increase "believability"?
2. Does using messages about civic duty resonate with the reader?
3. Or does reading about "jury duty" and "paying taxes" NOT resonate? (Are they irritating?)
4. Does using normative messaging resonate with the reader?

Thank you. **[Take back previous mailing.]** This is the third mailing you received. **[Give respondent mailing.]**

1. *If needed:* When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. What do you think the main point of this mailing is?
3. Did this seem the same as any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
4. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
5. What do you think about this sentence here? **[POINT TO SENTENCE THAT TALKS ABOUT "CIVIC DUTY"]**

6. What do you think about this sentence here? [POINT TO SENTENCE ABOUT 'MANY HOUSEHOLDS'(CWT & TTP) OR MILLIONS OF HOUSEHOLDS (FL)]

Mailing 4 - postcard:

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the fourth mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. *If needed:* When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. What do you think the main point of this mailing is?
3. Did this seem the same as any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
4. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)

Mailing 5 - final reminder pressure seal:

Research Questions:

1. **Does including deadline/due dates help to increase the message of urgency for the reader?**
2. **Do they think they would be more likely to respond given a firm date?**
3. **How does implementing a commitment device affect self-response?**
4. **Would this commitment device make you think you should mail the letter in?**

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the fifth mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. *If needed:* When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. What do you think the main point of this mailing is?
3. Did this seem the same as any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
4. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
5. If you had not responded, how would you have responded to the survey?
6. Did you notice a due date? What do you think about it?
7. *If needed:* What do you think about all of the different ways of completing the survey? Do you think that would make you more likely to complete the survey?

Side by side of all treatments:

Research Questions:

1. **What stands out to respondents in a side-by-side comparison of all treatments?**
2. **Does color cause any difficulties? (Readability/believability, 'official' government mail)**

Initial Letter:

Now I'm going to show you a few different versions of the first letter you looked at today [Place all four versions of mailing 1 in front of the respondent in a line].

1. What do you see as the difference, if any, between these letters?
2. Which version of the letter do you prefer, if any? Can you tell me more about that?
3. What do you think of the color used in these letters?
 - a. *If needed:* Did you find it easy or difficult to read? Can you tell me more about that?
 - b. *If needed:* Does this look like 'official' government mail? Can you tell me more about that?
4. [IF NOT ADMINISTERED FRESH LOOK DESIGN] What do you think of this? [POINT TO SIDEBAR in FRESH LOOK].
 - a. *If needed:* What do you like about it, if anything? What do you dislike about it, if anything? Can you tell me more about that?
5. [IF NOT ADMINISTERED CLASSIC WITH A TWIST DESIGN] What do you think of the icons in this version? [POINT TO ICON IN CLASSIC WITH A TWIST].
 - a. *If needed:* What do you like about the icons, if anything? What do you dislike about the icons, if anything? Can you tell me more about that?

Postcard:

1. What do you see as the difference, if any, between these postcards?
2. Is one version of the postcard easier to read than the others? *If yes:* What makes it easier to read?
3. Which version of the postcard do you prefer, if any? Can you tell me more about that?

Debriefing

Thank you. I have just a few more questions for you to wrap up.

1. In general, how likely would you be to read these materials if they came in the mail to you?
2. Was there a specific piece of mail we looked at today that stood out to you for any reason?
 - a. *If needed:* Which piece? Why did that piece stand out to you?
3. If you had received this mail, do you think you would complete the American Community Survey?
 - a. *If needed:* Tell me more about that.
4. Is there anything we could change about the letters that you think would make people more likely to respond to the American Community Survey?
5. Was there anything else that we haven't talked about that you would like to mention?

Great, thank you very much. Those are all of the questions that I had for you today. Thank you very much for your participation. [TURN OFF THE RECORDER.] Here is an envelope containing your \$40, and a voucher form that verifies I gave you the money. Please complete the information in the highlighted areas and sign and date. [HAND THE CASH INCENTIVE TO THE RESPONDENT AND COLLECT VOUCHER FORM.]

Cognitive Testing of ACS Strategic Framework Mail Materials - Round 2

RESPONDENT ID #: _____ DATE: ____ / ____ / ____

INTERVIEWER'S NAME: _____

START TIME: ____ : ____ AM / PM VERSION: _____

Introduction

Hello, my name is _____, and I work for the Census Bureau. Thank you for agreeing to help us today. Let me start by telling you a little about what we will be doing today.

Every year, the Census Bureau conducts a number of surveys. Today we are going to look at some of the envelopes, letters, postcards, and the questionnaire that you would get in the mail if your address had been selected to respond to a national survey called the American Community Survey.

[If needed: Because these are example mailings, they may not look quite as nice as they would if you received them in the mail.] We will go through some different pieces of mail one by one. After you've finished with one piece of mail, I will hand you the next. I'll explain each one to you as we go along.

As I give you these mailings, I'm going to ask you to treat each one as you would if it came to your home. Please go through these as you would at home, as if I were not there, but say out loud what you are thinking as you look at the mailings.

I'm also going to ask you some questions about the mailings and about your reactions to them. There are no right or wrong answers. I really want to hear your opinions and reactions to these pieces of mail, so don't hesitate to speak up whenever something is unclear. Please feel free to be honest.

[IF OBSERVER PRESENT]: I want to let you know that this interview is being observed by other Census Bureau staff. They are observing the interview because they are also interested in how the mailings work for people like you.

Do you have any questions about what we'll be doing?

Informed Consent

- [HAND RESPONDENT COPY OF THE CONSENT FORM.]

Before we start, I would like you to read over the document in front of you. This document explains a little bit about this interview and provides information about your rights as a respondent, such as that your participation is optional, all information you provide is confidential, and we won't use your name in any report. It also asks for your permission to have this session audio (if applicable: and video) recorded so that I can concentrate on what you are saying rather than having to take extensive notes. Please ask me any questions you have about this document. Once you have finished reading the document, please sign and date it.

- [RESPONDENT READS FORM THEN SIGNS AND DATES FORM]

Thank you for signing the consent form. I will also sign this form to show that I agree to everything in the form.

- [INTERVIEWER SIGNS AND DATES FORM]
- [IF RESPONDENT PROVIDES CONSENT TO HAVE THE SESSION RECORDED]: I will now turn on the recorder.
- [TURN ON RECORDER]

Think-Aloud

While you are looking at the materials I give you, I'd like you to tell me what's going through your mind. This could include what information you're seeing in each material, questions that come to your mind, and reactions you're having. You do not have to read aloud if you would not do that at home.

No practice for think aloud. Encourage respondents to think aloud as needed throughout interview, especially with first few mailing pieces:

- What are you looking at?
 - What are you thinking?
 - Remember to tell me what you are thinking about as you look at these mailings.
-

Observation

Research Questions:

1. Does the use of color, images, and novel structure enhance the appeal of the letters?
2. Do the strategies of reducing the amount of text and using plain language in the bodies of the letters improve readability and clarity of letter content?
3. Does including "OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope increase "believability"?
4. Do reducing text, using plain language, and the use of novel visual design elements make the letters look too "unofficial"?
5. Does Spanish messaging evoke any reaction?

Okay, let's get started.

- Make observation notes below (see questions in red text). Note any nonverbal reactions.
- If respondent indicates that they would not look at a piece of mail/would let mail pile up, note that but then ask them to look at it anyway.
- Let the respondent spend no more than 5 minutes looking at each mailing.
- Take back each mailing after respondent is finished with it—do not let them compare the mailings to each other until specified.
- **Hand materials to respondents SIDEWAYS, so that it is neither face up or face down.**

Mailing 1 - initial letter: Okay, let's get started. Imagine you received this piece of mail at your house. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R comment on "OFFICIAL US GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope?

___ Yes ___ No

If yes, what did they say? _____

2. Which way does R take materials out of the envelope?

___ Address side up ___ Address side down

3. What materials does R look at, and in what order? Mark "X" if respondent did not look at a material. Otherwise put a number to indicate the order.

___ Envelope, front ___ Envelope, back ___ Letter, front

___ Letter, back ___ Instruction card, front ___ Instruction card, back

4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

___ Yes, legitimate ___ Yes, unofficial ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

5. Does R comment on the instruction card?

___ Yes, confused by it ___ Yes, understand what it's for ___ No ___ Not sure

6. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

7. Does R comment on the coloring used?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

8. Does R comment on response being required?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

9. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, what did they say? _____

10. Does R read letter front; if so, how closely?

___ Did not look ___ Glanced ___ Skimmed ___ Read closely

11. Does R read FAQs on back of letter; if so, how closely?

___ Did not look ___ Glanced ___ Skimmed ___ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Note any comments R had on the back of the letter:

Other notes

Mailing 2 - first reminder letter, pressure seal: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you would receive a few days later. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Which way does R open pressure seal?

☐ Address side up ☐ Address side down

2. Does R look at both sides (address side and blank side)?

☐ Yes ☐ No

3. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

☐ Yes, legitimate ☐ Yes, unofficial ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces looks like it belongs with previous mailings?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment on? : _____

5. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

6. Does R make any unprompted comments about the community benefits mentioned in the letter?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment? : _____

7. Does R comment on the uses of the ACS data?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment? : _____

8. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

9. Does R read content inside pressure seal; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Mailing 3 - paper questionnaire package: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you *might* receive about a week later if you hadn't responded online by the time they put these in the mail. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R comment on "OFFICIAL US GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope?
___ Yes ___ No
If yes, what did they say? _____
2. Which way does R take materials out of the envelope?
___ Address side up ___ Address side down
3. What materials does R look at, and in what order? Mark "X" if respondent did not look at a material. Otherwise, put a number to indicate the order.
___ Outer envelope, front ___ Outer envelope, back ___ Letter, front ___ Letter, back
___ Questionnaire ___ Return envelope, front ___ Return envelope, back
4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?
___ Yes, legitimate ___ Yes, unofficial ___ No ___ Not sure
If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____
5. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?
___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure
6. Does R comment on the coloring used?
___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure
7. Does R make unprompted comments about the text about civic duty?
___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure
If yes, what did they comment? : _____
8. Does R make unprompted comments on the line about millions of households/many households completing survey?
___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure
If yes, what did they comment? : _____
9. Does R comment on response being required?
___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure
If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____
10. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?
___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure
If yes, what did they say? _____
11. Does R read letter front? If so, how closely?
___ Did not look ___ Glanced ___ Skimmed ___ Read closely
Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:
Note any comments R had on the back of the letter:
Other notes:

Mailing 4 - postcard: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you would receive a few days later if you received the questionnaire. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R look at both sides?

☐ Yes ☐ No

2. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

☐ Yes, legitimate ☐ Yes, unofficial ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

3. (Only in the 'Classic With a Twist' treatment) Does R comment on the bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

4. Does R comment on the coloring used?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

5. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment on: _____

6. Does R read content; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Mailing 5 – final reminder, pressure seal: Thank you. [\[Take previous mailing back.\]](#) Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you would receive about two weeks later if you had not yet responded. [\[Give respondent mailing.\]](#) Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Which way does R open pressure seal?

☐ Address side up ☐ Address side down

2. Does R look at both sides (address side and blank side)?

☐ Yes ☐ No

3. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

4. Does R comment on the due date?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment?: _____

5. Does R comment on the commitment device?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment?: _____

6. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

7. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they say? _____

8. Does R read content inside pressure seal; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Probing

Thank you. Now I have a few questions I'd like to ask you about the mailings.

- Only ask probe if not mentioned during think aloud.
- Take back each mailing after respondent is finished with it—do not let them compare the mailings to each other until specified.
- Hand materials to respondents SIDEWAYS, so that it is neither face up or face down.

Mailing 1 - initial letter:

Research Questions:

1. Does including “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelope increase “believability”?
2. Do changes to mailings intended to increase trust and legitimacy actually convey that to the reader? (i.e., adding FAQs about the survey, highlighting the Census logo, testimonies on back of letters from credible experts, using consistent coloring throughout mailings)

This is the first mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed*: Tell me more about that.)
3. *If needed*: After getting this letter, would you respond to the survey? Tell me more about that.
4. *If needed*: Do you think you have to respond to the survey?
5. *If R didn't obviously look at the back*: Did you notice the back of this letter? What do you think about it?

Now let's take a look at the envelope.

6. *If R didn't comment on the 'Official U.S. Government Mail' wording during observation*: Did you notice this wording on this envelope? [Point to 'Official U.S. Government Mail']
7. What do you think about this wording? *If needed*: Would this make you more or less likely to open up the envelope?

Mailing 2 - first reminder pressure seal:

Research Questions:

1. Does highlighting community benefits resonate with the reader?
2. Are they turned off by some benefits or conversely are they inspired by some benefits (enough so to feel that their response is important)?
3. Does highlighting the use of ACS data by non-profit organizations resonate with the reader?
4. [Classic w/a Twist and To The Point] Does including a “Reminder...” line in the top row of the second letter make the letter seem more friendly... less demanding?

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the second mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?

2. Did this seem the similar to the first mailing, or did it seem different? (*If needed*: Tell me more about that.)
3. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed*: Tell me more about that.)
4. If you hadn't responded already, after getting this letter do you think you would you respond to the survey?
5. **[IF PARTICIPANT ADMINISTERED CLASSIC WITH A TWIST OR TO THE POINT]** Please read the first line of the letter that says "Reminder". Did you notice this sentence when reading the letter? What do you think about this reminder? *If needed*: Do you think this reminder is helpful?
6. Did you notice anything in the letter about *why* you should complete the survey? Tell me more that.
 - a. *If participant mentioned the benefits or use of ACS data*: What do you think about that?
 - b. *If participant did not mention the benefits or use of ACS data* : **[POINT TO THE APPLICABLE SECTIONS ON BENEFITS AND USES OF DATA]** Please read this section(s). What do you think about this part of the letter? *If needed*: Would this make you more likely to complete the survey?

Mailing 3 - paper questionnaire package:

Research Questions:

1. Does including "OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope increase "believability"?
2. Does using messages about civic duty resonate with the reader? Or does reading about "jury duty" and "paying taxes" NOT resonate? (Are they irritating?)
3. Does using normative messaging resonate with the reader?

Thank you. **[Take back previous mailing.]** This is the third mailing you received. **[Give respondent mailing.]**

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. Did this seem similar to any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed*: Tell me more about that.)
3. What do you think about this sentence here? **[POINT TO SENTENCE THAT TALKS ABOUT "CIVIC DUTY"]**
If needed: Would this sentence make you more likely to complete the survey?
4. What do you think about this sentence here? **[POINT TO SENTENCE ABOUT 'MANY HOUSEHOLDS'(CWT & TTP) OR MILLIONS OF HOUSEHOLDS (FL)]** *If needed*: Would this sentence make you more likely to complete the survey?

Mailing 4 - postcard:

Thank you. **[Take back previous mailing.]** This is the fourth mailing you received. **[Give respondent mailing.]**

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. Did this seem similar to any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed*: Tell me more about that.)

Mailing 5 - final reminder pressure seal:

Research Questions:

1. Does including deadline/due dates help to increase the message of urgency for the reader?
2. Do they think they would be more likely to respond given a firm date?
3. How does implementing a commitment device affect self-response?
4. Would this commitment device make you think you should mail the letter in?

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the fifth mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. Did this seem similar to any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
3. If you had not responded, how would you have responded to the survey?
4. Did you notice a due date? What do you think about it? *If needed:* Would this make you more likely to complete the survey?
5. *If needed:* What do you think about all of the different ways of completing the survey? Do you think that would make you more likely to complete the survey?

Side by side of all treatments:

Research Questions:

1. What stands out to respondents in a side-by-side comparison of all treatments?
2. Does color cause any difficulties? (Readability/believability, 'official' government mail)

Initial Letter:

Now I'm going to show you a few different versions of the first letter you looked at today [Place all four versions of mailing 1 in front of the respondent in a line]. This letter would go in the first mailing with the instruction card [Hold up or point to M1 envelope]. Take a minute to look over the letters and think aloud as you do. Mention anything you're thinking – what's standing out to you, what do you like or dislike, etc.

1. [Note highlights of what R says as they look over the letters and think aloud.]
2. Is one version of the letter easier to read than the others? Can you tell me more about that
3. Which version of the letter do you prefer, if any? Can you tell me more about that
4. What do you think of the color used in these letters?
 - a. Did you find it easy or difficult to read? Can you tell me more about that?
 - b. Does this look like 'official' government mail? Can you tell me more about that?
5. [IF NOT ADMINISTERED FRESH LOOK DESIGN] What do you think of this? [POINT TO SIDEBAR IN FRESH LOOK].
 - a. *If needed:* What do you like about it, if anything? What do you dislike about it, if anything? Can you tell me more about that?
6. [IF NOT ADMINISTERED CLASSIC WITH A TWIST DESIGN] What do you think of the icons in this version? [POINT TO ICON IN CLASSIC WITH A TWIST].

- a. *If needed:* What do you like about the icons, if anything? What do you dislike about the icons, if anything? Can you tell me more about that?

Postcard:

Now we're going to do the same thing with different versions of the postcard. Take a minute to look over the postcards and think aloud as you do. Mention anything you're thinking – what's standing out to you, what do you like or dislike, etc.

1. [Note highlights of what R says as they look over the letters and think aloud.]
2. Is one version of the postcard easier to read than the others? *If yes:* What makes it easier to read?
3. Which version of the postcard do you prefer, if any? Can you tell me more about that?

Debriefing

Thank you. I have just a few more questions for you to wrap up.

1. In general, how likely would you be to read these materials if they came in the mail to you?
2. Was there a specific piece of mail we looked at today that stood out to you for any reason?
 - a. *If needed:* Which piece? Why did that piece stand out to you?
3. If you had received this mail, do you think you would complete the American Community Survey?
 - a. *If needed:* Tell me more about that.
4. Is there anything we could change about the letters that you think would make people more likely to respond to the American Community Survey?
5. Was there anything else that we haven't talked about that you would like to mention?

Great, thank you very much. Those are all of the questions that I had for you today. Thank you very much for your participation. [TURN OFF THE RECORDER.] Here is an envelope containing your \$40, and a voucher form that verifies I gave you the money. Please complete the information in the highlighted areas and sign and date. [HAND THE CASH INCENTIVE TO THE RESPONDENT AND COLLECT VOUCHER FORM.]

Cognitive Testing of ACS Strategic Framework Mail Materials Round - 3

RESPONDENT ID #: _____ DATE: ____ / ____ / ____

INTERVIEWER'S NAME: _____

START TIME: ____ : ____ AM / PM VERSION: _____

Introduction

Hello, my name is _____, and I work for the Census Bureau. Thank you for agreeing to help us today. Let me start by telling you a little about what we will be doing today.

Every year, the Census Bureau conducts a number of surveys. Today we are going to look at some of the envelopes, letters, postcards, and the questionnaire that you would get in the mail if your address had been selected to respond to a national survey called the American Community Survey.

[If needed: Because these are example mailings, they may not look quite as nice as they would if you received them in the mail.] We will go through some different pieces of mail one by one. After you've finished with one piece of mail, I will hand you the next. I'll explain each one to you as we go along.

As I give you these mailings, I'm going to ask you to treat each one as you would if it came to your home. Please go through these as you would at home, as if I were not there, but say out loud what you are thinking as you look at the mailings.

I'm also going to ask you some questions about the mailings and about your reactions to them. There are no right or wrong answers. I really want to hear your opinions and reactions to these pieces of mail, so don't hesitate to speak up whenever something is unclear. Please feel free to be honest.

[IF OBSERVER PRESENT]: I want to let you know that this interview is being observed by other Census Bureau staff. They are observing the interview because they are also interested in how the mailings work for people like you.

Do you have any questions about what we'll be doing?

Informed Consent

- [HAND RESPONDENT COPY OF THE CONSENT FORM.]

Before we start, I would like you to read over the document in front of you. This document explains a little bit about this interview and provides information about your rights as a respondent, such as that your participation is optional, all information you provide is confidential, and we won't use your name in any report. It also asks for your permission to have this session audio (if applicable: and video) recorded so that I can concentrate on what you are saying rather than having to take extensive notes. Please ask me any questions you have about this document. Once you have finished reading the document, please sign and date it.

- [RESPONDENT READS FORM THEN SIGNS AND DATES FORM]

Thank you for signing the consent form. I will also sign this form to show that I agree to everything in the form.

- [INTERVIEWER SIGNS AND DATES FORM]
- [IF RESPONDENT PROVIDES CONSENT TO HAVE THE SESSION RECORDED]: I will now turn on the recorder.
- [TURN ON RECORDER]

Think-Aloud

While you are looking at the materials I give you, I'd like you to tell me what's going through your mind. This could include what information you're seeing in each material, questions that come to your mind, and reactions you're having. You do not have to read aloud if you would not do that at home.

No practice for think aloud. Encourage respondents to think aloud as needed throughout interview, especially with first few mailing pieces:

- What are you looking at?
 - What are you thinking?
 - Remember to tell me what you are thinking about as you look at these mailings.
-

Observation

Research Questions:

1. Does the use of color, images, and novel structure enhance the appeal of the letters?
2. Do the strategies of reducing the amount of text and using plain language in the bodies of the letters improve readability and clarity of letter content?
3. Does including “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelope increase “believability”?
4. Do reducing text, using plain language, and the use of novel visual design elements make the letters look too “unofficial”?
5. Does Spanish messaging evoke any reaction?

Okay, let’s get started.

- Make observation notes below (see questions in red text). Note any nonverbal reactions.
- If respondent indicates that they would not look at a piece of mail/would let mail pile up, note that but then ask them to look at it anyway.
- Let the respondent spend no more than 5 minutes looking at each mailing.
- Take back each mailing after respondent is finished with it—do not let them compare the mailings to each other until specified.
- **Hand materials to respondents SIDEWAYS, so that it is neither face up or face down.**

Mailing 1 - initial letter: Okay, let's get started. Imagine you received this piece of mail at your house. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R comment on "OFFICIAL US GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope?

___ Yes ___ No

If yes, what did they say? _____

2. Which way does R take materials out of the envelope?

___ Address side up ___ Address side down

3. What materials does R look at, and in what order? Mark "X" if respondent did not look at a material. Otherwise put a number to indicate the order.

___ Envelope, front ___ Envelope, back ___ Letter, front

___ Letter, back ___ Instruction card, front ___ Instruction card, back

4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

___ Yes, legitimate ___ Yes, unofficial ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

5. Does R comment on the point of the instruction card?

___ Yes, confused by it ___ Yes, understand what it's for ___ No ___ Not sure

6. Does R look for the User ID on the instruction card?

___ Yes, finds easily ___ Yes, finds but with some difficulty ___ Yes, but is not able to find

___ No, does not look for it ___ Not sure

7. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

8. Does R comment on the coloring used?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

9. Does R comment on response being required?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

10. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?

___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure

If yes, what did they say? _____

11. Does R read letter front; if so, how closely?

___ Did not look ___ Glanced ___ Skimmed ___ Read closely

12. Does R read FAQs on back of letter; if so, how closely?

___ Did not look ___ Glanced ___ Skimmed ___ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Note any comments R had on the back of the letter:

Other notes

Mailing 2 - first reminder letter, pressure seal: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you would receive a few days later. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Which way does R open pressure seal?

☐ Address side up ☐ Address side down

2. Does R look at both sides (address side and blank side)?

☐ Yes ☐ No

3. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

☐ Yes, legitimate ☐ Yes, unofficial ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces looks like it belongs with previous mailings?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment on? : _____

5. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

6. Does R make any unprompted comments about the community benefits mentioned in the letter?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment? : _____

7. Does R comment on the uses of the ACS data?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment? : _____

8. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

9. Does R read content inside pressure seal; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Mailing 3 - paper questionnaire package: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you *might* receive about a week later if you hadn't responded online by the time they put these in the mail. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R comment on "OFFICIAL US GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope?
☐ Yes ☐ No
If yes, what did they say? _____
2. Which way does R take materials out of the envelope?
☐ Address side up ☐ Address side down
3. What materials does R look at, and in what order? Mark "X" if respondent did not look at a material. Otherwise, put a number to indicate the order.
☐ Outer envelope, front ☐ Outer envelope, back ☐ Letter, front ☐ Letter, back
☐ Questionnaire ☐ Return envelope, front ☐ Return envelope, back
4. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?
☐ Yes, legitimate ☐ Yes, unofficial ☐ No ☐ Not sure
If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____
5. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?
☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure
6. Does R comment on the coloring used?
☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure
7. Does R make unprompted comments about the text about civic duty?
☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure
If yes, what did they comment? : _____
8. Does R make unprompted comments on the line about millions of households/many households completing survey?
☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure
If yes, what did they comment? : _____
9. Does R comment on response being required?
☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure
If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____
10. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?
☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure
If yes, what did they say? _____
11. Does R read letter front? If so, how closely?
☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely
12. Does R comment on the front page of the questionnaire?
☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure
If yes, what did they say? _____

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Mailing 4 - postcard: Thank you. [Take previous mailing back.] Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you would receive a few days later if you received the questionnaire. [Give respondent mailing.] Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R look at both sides?

☐ Yes ☐ No

2. Does R comment on whether the mail pieces look legitimate or unofficial?

☐ Yes, legitimate ☐ Yes, unofficial ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what piece(s) were they referring to when they commented? (Can be more than one place): _____

3. (Only in the 'Classic With a Twist' treatment) Does R comment on the bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

4. Does R comment on the coloring used?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

5. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment on: _____

6. Does R read content; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Mailing 5 – final reminder, pressure seal: Thank you. [\[Take previous mailing back.\]](#) Let's move onto the next piece of mail, which you would receive about two weeks later if you had not yet responded. [\[Give respondent mailing.\]](#) Please treat it as you would if you were receiving this piece of mail at your home.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Which way does R open pressure seal?

☐ Address side up ☐ Address side down

2. Does R look at both sides (address side and blank side)?

☐ Yes ☐ No

3. Does R comment on the icon/sidebar/bullet format?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

4. Does R comment on the due date?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment?: _____

5. Does R comment on the commitment device?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they comment?: _____

6. Does R comment on response being required?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, where? (Can be more than one place): _____

7. Does R comment on the new ramped up sentences in the first paragraph? ("We have sent several requests.... Required..")

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they say? _____

8. Does R comment on the Spanish messaging?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

If yes, what did they say? _____

9. Does R read content inside pressure seal; if so, how closely?

☐ Did not look ☐ Glanced ☐ Skimmed ☐ Read closely

Note any questions R asked/comments R made about this mailing:

Other notes:

Probing

Thank you. Now I have a few questions I'd like to ask you about the mailings.

- Only ask probe if not mentioned during think aloud.
- Take back each mailing after respondent is finished with it—do not let them compare the mailings to each other until specified.
- Hand materials to respondents SIDEWAYS, so that it is neither face up or face down.

Mailing 1 - initial letter:

Research Questions:

1. Does including "OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL" on the envelope increase "believability"?
2. Do changes to mailings intended to increase trust and legitimacy actually convey that to the reader? (i.e., adding FAQs about the survey, highlighting the Census logo, using consistent coloring throughout mailings)
3. Is there anything in particular in M1 that would make R more likely to respond?
4. Is there anything in particular in M1 that would make R less likely to respond?
5. Is it clear what the instruction card is for? Is it clear where the user ID can be found?

This is the first mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed*: Tell me more about that.)
3. *If needed*: Do you think you have to respond to the survey?
4. *If R didn't obviously look at the back*: Did you notice the back of this letter? What do you think about it?
5. Is there anything in the mailing that would make you more likely to respond to the survey?
6. Is there anything in the mailing that would make you less likely to respond to the survey?
7. *If needed*: After getting this letter, would you respond to the survey? Tell me more about that.
8. *If R has not mentioned looking for the user ID during think aloud or previous probes*: Did you notice anything about what to do to [respond online/log in to respond]? Can you say more about that?
 - a. *If R mentioned ID but didn't look*: How would you find the user ID to log in?

Mailing 1 URL task:

We are going to have Rs attempt to navigate to the website. There are two reasons for this: 1. See if the new URL causes problems; and 2. See if the image pointing to the user ID is helpful. The question text below is intended to find out if they would go online after receiving the letter, and if so, what device they would use so that we can tailor the task. If they have already mentioned this information, rephrase this as a confirmation rather than asking them for the same info again.

Research Questions:

1. Does getting rid of the “https://” cause any unintended consequences that make it more difficult to get to the ACS response landing page?
2. Does the image on the website help R easily locate the user ID on the instruction card?

Step 1

- *If R has said they would respond to the survey or they would go online/go to the url to check it out:*
You said that you would [respond online/go online to check out the website]. What device would you use to do that?
- *If R has NOT said they would respond to the survey or they would go online/go to the url to check it out:*
Do you think you would respond online or go online to check out the website? *If yes:* What device would you use to do that?

Step 2

- *If R said they would go online with their smartphone:*
Would you be willing to use your smartphone now and do what you would do if you were at home? *If yes:* Please do that now and try to think aloud and say what you are doing as you do so.
- *If no to smartphone or If R said they would go online with a computer or tablet:*
[Give R the laptop] Can you use this laptop and do what you would do if you were going online at home? Please try to think aloud as you do so.

OBSERVE (DO NOT READ TO RESPONDENT):

1. Does R comment on any difficulty with the task?
___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure
If yes or not sure, what did they say?: _____
2. Does R comment on the image with the User ID?
___ Yes ___ No ___ Not sure
If yes or not sure, what did they say?: _____

Probes:

1. How easy or difficult was it to navigate to the website? Can you tell me more about that?
2. How easy or difficult was it to find the user ID to log in? Can you tell me more about that?
3. *If needed:* Was there anything on the web page that helped you figure out how to log in? Can you tell me more about that?

Mailing 2 - first reminder pressure seal:

Research Questions:

1. Does highlighting community benefits resonate with the reader?

2. Are they turned off by some benefits or conversely are they inspired by some benefits (enough so to feel that their response is important)?
3. Does highlighting the use of ACS data by non-profit organizations resonate with the reader?
4. [Classic w/a Twist and To The Point] Does including a “Reminder...” line in the top row of the second letter make the letter seem more friendly... less demanding?
5. Is there anything in particular in M2 that would make R more likely to respond?
6. Is there anything in particular in M2 that would make R less likely to respond?

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the second mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. Did this seem the similar to the first mailing, or did it seem different? (*If needed*: Tell me more about that.)
3. What would you have done next after reading it? (*If needed*: Tell me more about that.)
4. Is there anything in the mailing that would make you more likely to respond to the survey?
5. Is there anything in the mailing that would make you less likely to respond to the survey?
6. [IF PARTICIPANT ADMINISTERED CLASSIC WITH A TWIST OR TO THE POINT] Please read the first line of the letter that says “Reminder”. Did you notice this sentence when reading the letter? What do you think about this reminder? *If needed*: Do you think this reminder is helpful?
7. Did you notice anything in the letter about *why* you should complete the survey? Tell me more that.
 - a. *If participant mentioned the benefits or use of ACS data*: What do you think about that?
 - b. *If participant did not mention the benefits or use of ACS data* : [POINT TO THE APPLICABLE SECTIONS ON BENEFITS AND USES OF DATA] Please read this section(s). What do you think about this part of the letter? *If needed*: Would this make you more likely to complete the survey?

Mailing 3 - paper questionnaire package:

Research Questions:

1. Does including “OFFICIAL U.S. GOVERNMENT MAIL” on the envelope increase “believability”?
2. Does using messages about civic responsibility resonate with the reader?
3. Which of the civic responsibility examples appeals to the R the most?

4. **Is there a particular civic responsibility example that is off-putting? Does using normative messaging resonate with the reader?**
5. **Is there anything in particular in M3 that would make R more likely to respond?**
6. **Is there anything in particular in M3 that would make R less likely to respond?**

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the third mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. Did this seem similar to any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
3. Is there anything in the mailing that would make you more likely to respond to the survey?
4. Is there anything in the mailing that would make you less likely to respond to the survey?
5. What do you think about this sentence here? [POINT TO SENTENCE THAT TALKS ABOUT “CIVIC DUTY”]
 - a. *If needed:* Would this sentence make you more likely to complete the survey?
 - b. Does one of the examples in the sentence appeal to you more than the others? Can you say more about that?
 - c. Are any of the examples in the sentence that you don’t like? Can you say more about that?
6. What do you think about this sentence here? [POINT TO SENTENCE ABOUT ‘MANY HOUSEHOLDS’(CWT & TTP) OR MILLIONS OF HOUSEHOLDS (FL)] *If needed:* Would this sentence make you more likely to complete the survey?

Mailing 4 - postcard:

Research Questions:

1. **Is there anything in particular in M4 that would make R more likely to respond?**
2. **Is there anything in particular in M4 that would make R less likely to respond?**

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the fourth mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. Did this seem similar to any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
3. Is there anything in the postcard that would make you more likely to respond to the survey?
4. Is there anything in the postcard that would make you less likely to respond to the survey?

Mailing 5 - final reminder pressure seal:

Research Questions:

1. Does including deadline/due dates help to increase the message of urgency for the reader?
2. Do they think they would be more likely to respond given a firm date?
3. How does implementing a commitment device affect self-response?
4. Would this commitment device make Rs think they should mail the letter in?
5. How do Rs react to the ramped up wording in the first paragraph of M5?
6. Is there anything in particular in M5 that would make R more likely to respond?
7. Is there anything in particular in M5 that would make R less likely to respond?

Thank you. [Take back previous mailing.] This is the fifth mailing you received. [Give respondent mailing.]

1. When I first gave you this, what did you notice about it?
2. Did this seem similar to any of the previous mailings you saw, or did it seem different? (*If needed:* Tell me more about that.)
3. Is there anything in the letter that would make you more likely to respond to the survey?
4. Is there anything in the letter that would make you less likely to respond to the survey?
5. If you had not responded, how would you have responded to the survey?
6. Did you notice a due date? What do you think about it? *If needed:* Would this make you more likely to complete the survey?
7. *If needed:* What do you think about all of the different ways of completing the survey? Do you think that would make you more likely to complete the survey?

Side by side of all treatments:

Research Questions:

1. What stands out to respondents in a side-by-side comparison of all treatments?
2. Does one version motivate Rs to respond more than the other versions?
3. Does one version increase the likelihood of R reading the letter?
4. Does color cause any difficulties? (Readability/believability, 'official' government mail)

Mailing 2 letter:

Now I'm going to show you a few different versions of the second letter you looked at today [Shuffle order and place all four versions of mailing 2 in front of the respondent in a line]. This letter would be a pressure seal mailer where you have to rip off the sides to open it. Take a minute to look over the letters and think aloud as you do. Mention anything you're thinking – what's standing out to you, what do you like or dislike, etc.

[Interviewer – assess how much time is left. If you’re starting to run low on time, wrap up the think aloud after a few minutes. Probes are ordered by importance if you need to skip some due to time.]

1. [Note highlights of what R says as they look over the letters and think aloud.]
2. Which version of the letter would you be more likely to read, if any? Can you tell me more about that?
3. Would any version of the letter make you more likely to respond to the survey? Can you tell me more about that?
4. Is one version of the letter easier to read than the others? Can you tell me more about that?
5. [IF R HAS NOT COMMENTED ON THE SIDE BAR AT ANY POINT] What do you think of this? [POINT TO SIDEBAR IN FRESH LOOK].
 - a. *If needed:* What do you like about it, if anything? What do you dislike about it, if anything? Can you tell me more about that?
6. [IF R HAS NOT COMMENTED ON THE ICONS AT ANY POINT] What do you think of the icons in this version? [POINT TO ICON IN CLASSIC WITH A TWIST].
 - a. *If needed:* What do you like about the icons, if anything? What do you dislike about the icons, if anything? Can you tell me more about that?

Mailing 3 letter:

Now we’re going to do the same thing with different versions of another letter. [Shuffle order and place all four versions of mailing 2 in front of the respondent in a line]. This letter would go in the third mailing with the paper questionnaire [Hold up or point to M3 envelope]. Take a minute to look over the letters and think aloud as you do. Mention anything you’re thinking – what’s standing out to you, what do you like or dislike, etc.

[Interviewer – assess how much time is left. If you’re starting to run low on time, wrap up the think aloud after a few minutes. Probes are ordered by importance if you need to skip some due to time.]

1. [Note highlights of what R says as they look over the letters and think aloud.]
2. Which version of the letter would you be more likely to read, if any? Can you tell me more about that?
3. Would any version of the letter make you more likely to respond to the survey? Can you tell me more about that?
4. What do you think of the color used in these letters?
 - a. Did you find it easy or difficult to read? Can you tell me more about that?
 - b. Do the letters with color look like ‘official’ government mail? Can you tell me more about that?
5. Is there one version of the letter easier to read than the others? *If yes:* What makes it easier to read?

Front of Questionnaire:

[Interviewer – assess how much time is left. This section is okay to skip if you are out of time.]

Now we're going to do the same thing with two versions of front page of the paper questionnaire. Take a minute to look over the two versions of the front page and think aloud as you do. Mention anything you're thinking – what's standing out to you, what do you like or dislike, etc.

1. [Note highlights of what R says as they look over questionnaire covers and think aloud.]
2. Is one version of the front page easier to read than the others? *If yes:* What makes it easier to read?
3. Is there one version of the front page that would make you more likely to respond to the survey? Can you say more about that?
4. *If needed:* Would the front page make you more likely to respond online or using the paper questionnaire?

Debriefing

Thank you. I have just a few more questions for you to wrap up.

1. In general, how likely would you be to read these materials if they came in the mail to you?
2. Was there a specific piece of mail we looked at today that stood out to you for any reason?
 - a. *If needed:* Which piece? Why did that piece stand out to you?
3. Is there anything we could change about the letters that you think would make people more likely to respond to the American Community Survey?
4. Was there anything else that we haven't talked about that you would like to mention?

Great, thank you very much. Those are all of the questions that I had for you today. Thank you very much for your participation. [TURN OFF THE RECORDER.] Here is an envelope containing your \$40, and a voucher form that verifies I gave you the money. Please complete the information in the highlighted areas and sign and date. [HAND THE CASH INCENTIVE TO THE RESPONDENT AND COLLECT VOUCHER FORM.]